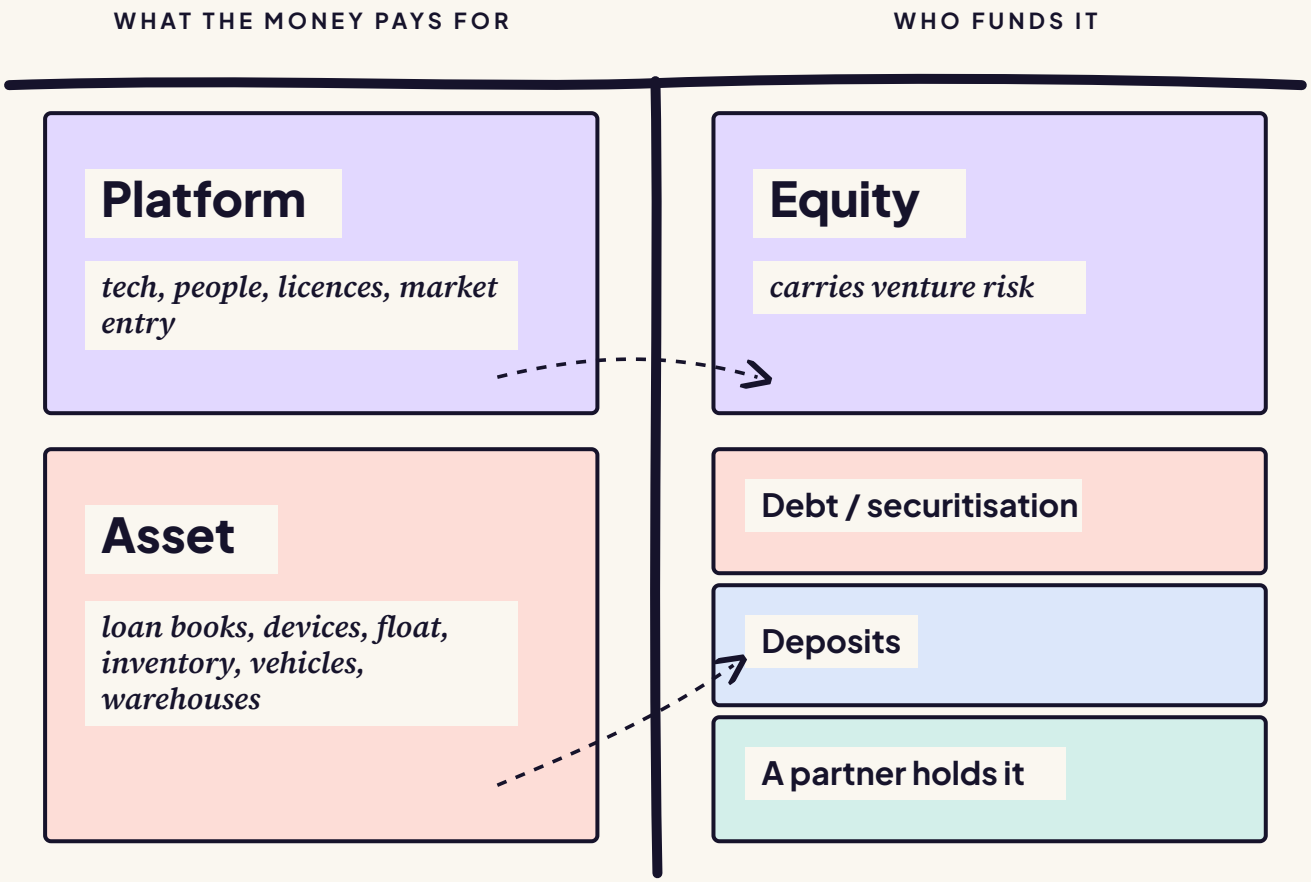
A DREAM VC CAPSTONE PROJECT · INVESTOR ACCELERATOR 2026

Who carries the asset?

How African founders use capital as a strategic tool: nine cases, one framework



AUTHORS

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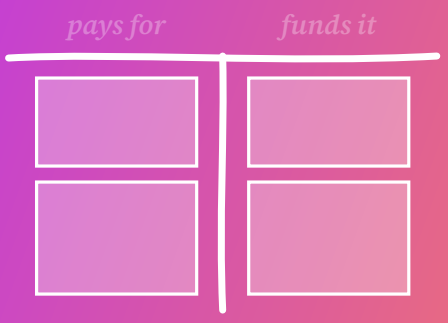
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OPENING

00

Introduction



Background and research motivation

Africa's venture ecosystem has grown rapidly: Partech Africa reports annual startup funding rising from under $300M in 2015 to $6.5B in 2022, of which $4.9B was equity and $1.55B debt (Partech Africa, January 2023), drawing global institutions, development finance institutions and sovereign funds alongside local managers. Research from the Africa Private Capital Association (AVCA), Partech, Africa: The Big Deal, FSD Africa and FinDev Canada has followed, much of it from the investor's perspective: who deployed capital, where, at what valuations and with what returns.

The founder's side is less systematically documented: not how much capital was raised, but how it was used strategically. When did founders raise, and when did they refuse? Which instruments did they choose, and why? Was the investor mix built around the best term sheet or long-term strategic relationships? Why stay lean through a devaluation rather than dilute to build a war chest?

This capstone examines how founders in nine companies made those choices. Because capital strategy is contextual, the aim is not a formula but a sharper shared vocabulary for financing decisions, and a set of documented examples, for founders and investors alike.

> *The founder's side is less systematically documented: not how much capital was raised, but how it was used strategically.*

RESEARCH QUESTION

How have some of Africa's most successful founders used capital as a strategic tool throughout their growth journey, and what can founders and investors learn from their financing decisions?

Two sub-questions follow: how did each company's financing choices relate to its business model and operating context; and which patterns recur across the cases, where do they break down, and what conditions explain the difference?

Defining "success"

Success is defined by observable indicators. A company is treated as a scaled case if it meets at least two of the following:

- demonstrable scale (a consistent, disclosed revenue base);
- geographic expansion beyond the home market;
- meaningful follow-on institutional funding; or
- a documented exit or partial liquidity event.

Five companies meet this test: M-KOPA, MNT-Halan, NALA, Moniepoint and LemFi. Autogirl, Feegor and Earthbond do not yet meet it on disclosed evidence (Autogirl has expanded into Ghana, but its revenue scale is not public); they are included as early-stage cases for the way they designed their capital needs, not as proven successes. Sendy, which closed in 2023, is the cautionary case: a company that attracted institutional capital and expanded across markets before failing. Moove's 2026 exit from Nigeria is used as a comparator rather than a full case, because the seven dimensions were not applied to it.

Scope and structure

The capstone profiles nine fintech and logistics companies across West, East and North Africa against a common framework. Section 2 sets out the method and its limits; Section 3 reviews the literature; Sections 4 and 5 present the cases; Section 6 compares them; Section 7 presents a capital-strategy framework for founders and investors; Section 8 sets out implications for investors; and Section 9 concludes.

Platform capital and asset capital: two jobs, two kinds of money

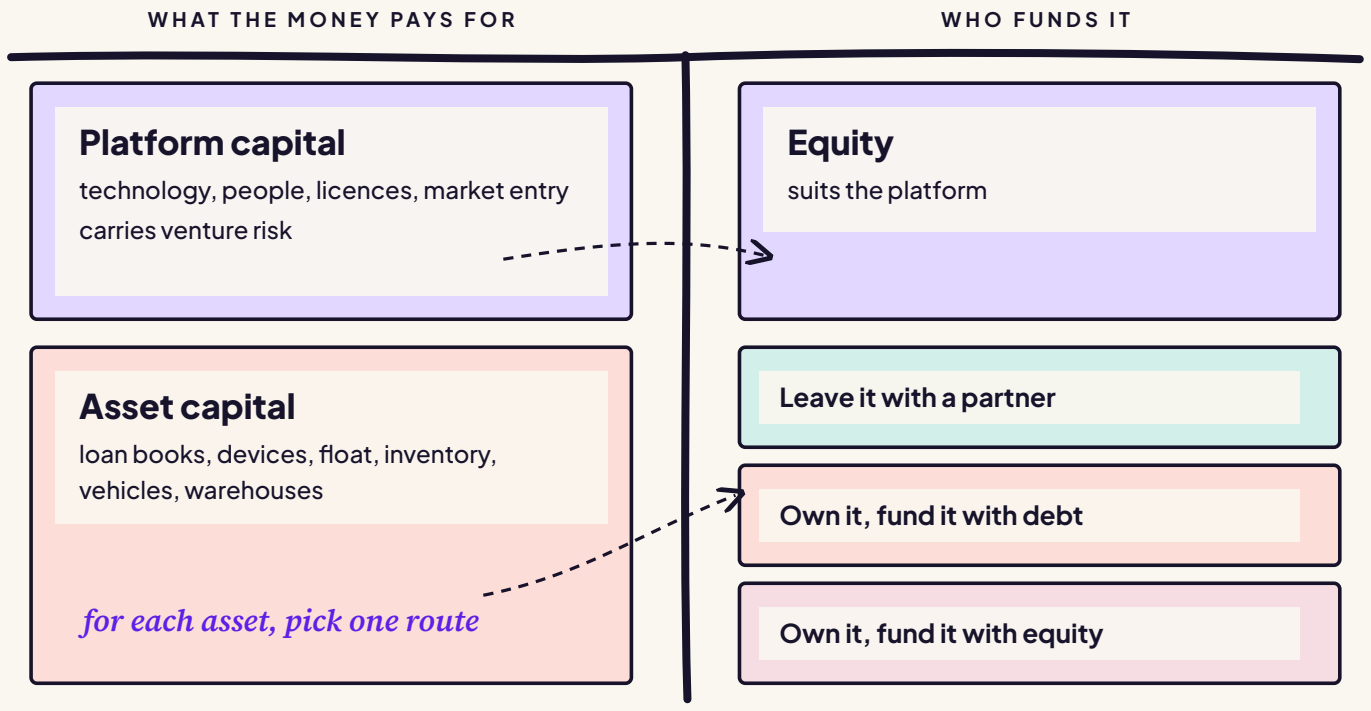
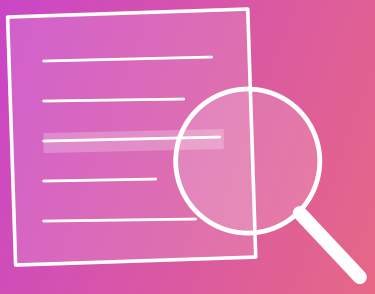


Figure 1 The study's central distinction. Platform capital funds technology, people, licences and market entry, carries venture risk and suits equity; asset capital funds loan books, devices, float, inventory, vehicles and warehouses. Source: Section 07, Step 1.

SECTION 01

01



Executive summary

This capstone asks how a set of African founders have used capital as a strategic tool, and what founders and investors can learn from their financing decisions. It is an exploratory, qualitative comparison of nine fintech and logistics companies across East, North and West Africa, based on public sources, and assesses each against seven dimensions: funding timing, instrument choice, investor selection, dilution management, follow-on funding, debt versus equity, and decisions to decline or delay capital.

The sample comprises five scaled companies (M-KOPA, MNT-Halan, NALA, Moniepoint and LemFi), three early-stage companies (Autogirl, Feegor and Earthbond) and one cautionary case (Sendy), read alongside Moove's 2026 exit from Nigeria. The sample is purposive, not representative, and the findings are patterns to test rather than causal laws.

Across the cases, one question recurs: who carries the asset and its risk. The answer is closely associated with how much capital a company needs, how flexibly it can finance itself and how exposed it is to funding shocks, although the sample cannot show that it caused those outcomes. M-KOPA finances customer devices with debt and reserves equity mainly for its platform, extending about $1.5B of credit by 2024 on roughly $245M of equity raised by 2023. MNT-Halan funds its Egyptian-pound loan book largely through local-currency securitisation. Moniepoint, a licensed microfinance bank, has raised over $280M of equity and can fund lending from deposits. NALA and LemFi built their core payments businesses on equity, and both have since moved toward debt-related activity: NALA through a 2026 credit facility to pre-fund payment corridors, LemFi through its 2025 acquisition of credit-scoring business Pillar. Autogirl, Feegor and Earthbond reached the market on small sums by leaving vehicles, delivery and loans with partners.

> *The findings are patterns to test rather than causal laws.*

Four findings stand out

1

Who owns and finances the asset shapes the capital strategy

Its effect depends on cash-flow predictability, lender availability, currency, the contractual allocation of risk and dependence on any single platform or partner. Sendy, which added fulfilment and supply lines funded largely with equity before closing in 2023, and Moove, whose Nigerian vehicle finance was linked to ride-hailing earnings, illustrate the downside; neither outcome has a single cause.

2

Partners first, then the balance sheet

Several founders left risk with partners until they could price it, then financed assets directly once data and lenders were available; this is a context-dependent heuristic, not a universal progression.

3

Raising from strength

Founders who raised from strength, such as NALA after reaching profitability, attracted strong syndicates in weak markets, although the terms they obtained are rarely public.

4

Investor selection tracked the stage

Investor selection tracked each stage's capital need, the customers' market and the intended exit.

The paper closes with an African Founder Capital-Strategy Framework: a sequence of questions on what is being financed, who should own the asset and carry its risks, which instrument fits, what conditions must hold first, and what happens if a lender, platform or partner relationship changes. The framework separates whether an instrument suits a business in principle from whether it is available and economic in a given market.

For founders, the practical implication is to diagnose the asset before sizing the raise. For investors, it is to underwrite the capital structure and the contracts that transfer risk, not only the company. The evidence base is uneven: dilution is rarely disclosed, debt terms are seldom public, several figures rest on press reports and founder statements, and three cases are too early for their outcomes to be judged.

THE SEQUENCE, AS THE CASES SHOW IT

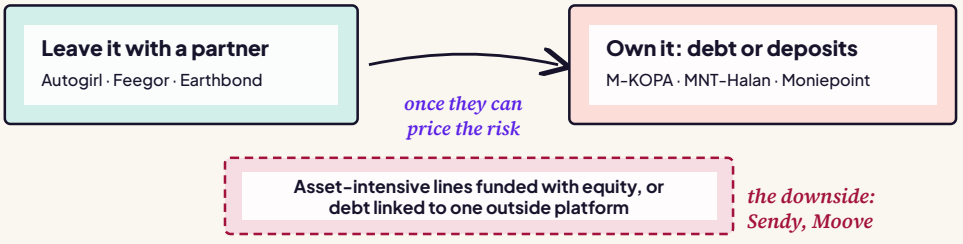


Figure 2 Findings one and two in one picture: a context-dependent heuristic, not a universal progression. NALA and LemFi built their core payments businesses on equity. Source: Sections 04–06.

THE MAIN POINT IN ONE PICTURE

How the asset and its risk move

Every case in this study turns on the same question: when a business needs vehicles, stock, devices, float or loans, which party holds the asset and which carries its risk. The four arrangements below summarise the answers the cases give. Each is a simplification: the precise split of risk depends on contracts and facility terms, which are rarely public.

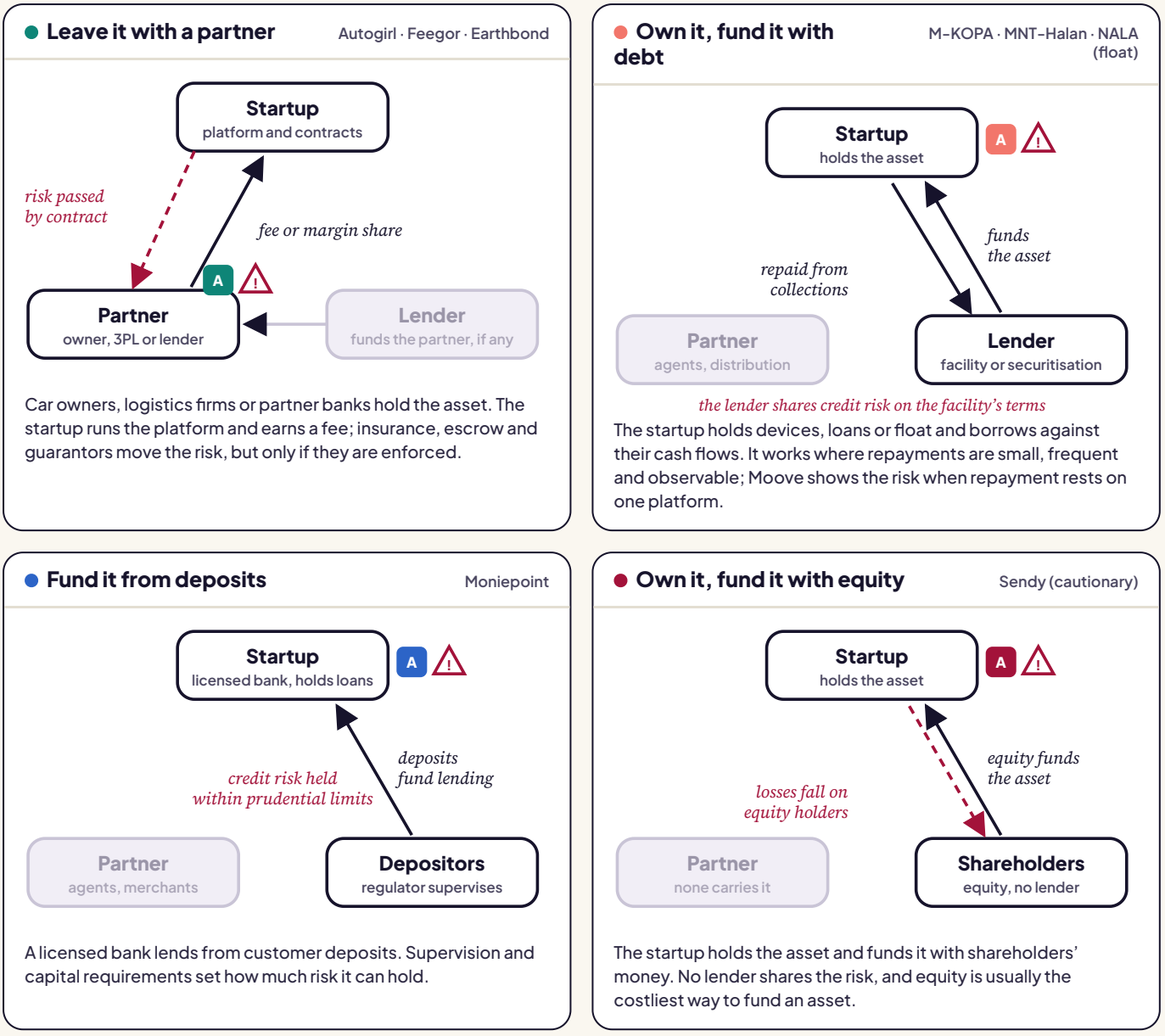
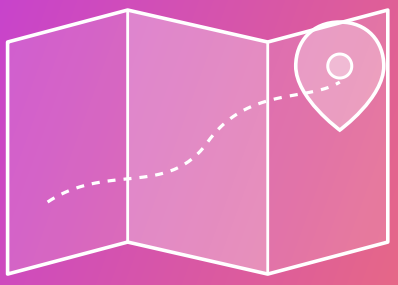


Figure 3 Who holds the asset and who carries its risk under each route. NALA and LemFi's core payments businesses need no financeable asset; NALA's 2026 corridor facility funds its float with debt. Sources: Sections 04–07.

SECTION 02

02



Methodology and analytical framework

Research design

The study is an exploratory, qualitative, comparative multiple-case study based on desk research. It relies on publicly available material, listed by case in the bibliography. Its purpose is to identify recurring patterns in founder financing decisions and the conditions under which they hold, not to estimate the effect of any financing choice on company outcomes.

Case selection criteria

Cases were limited to **fintech** and **logistics** because they place contrasting demands on capital: fintech ranges from asset-light payments to balance-sheet lending, while logistics tends to be asset-intensive and thin-margin. Within that filter, cases were selected purposively to vary region, business model, stage and outcome, and to include at least one company that failed after raising institutional capital. The scaled cases also required a public record of funding rounds and investors; the early-stage cases were chosen for how they designed their capital needs, and their public records are thinner. The selected cases are:

CASE	SECTOR AND CAPITAL STORY
1 · M-KOPA (Kenya)	Fintech, asset financing. Debt-funded assets, equity-funded platform.
2 · MNT-Halan (Egypt)	Fintech with logistics roots. Local-currency securitisation, raising through devaluation, 2026 EGX listing.
3 · NALA (Tanzania)	Fintech, payments. Pivot before institutional capital; Series A raised while profitable; 2026 credit facility to pre-fund payments.
4 · Sendy (Kenya)	Logistics, cautionary case. Asset-light transport marketplace that added fulfilment and supply lines funded largely with equity; closed in 2023.
5 · Moniepoint (Nigeria)	Fintech, business payments and banking. Revenue-funded until 2019; licensed microfinance bank; over $280M of equity raised.
6 · Autogirl (Nigeria)	Logistics and mobility, peer-to-peer vehicle rentals. Largely revenue-funded since 2019, with car owners financing the fleet; expanded to Ghana in 2024.
7 · Feegor (Nigeria)	Logistics and B2B commerce, wholesale sourcing marketplace. Asset-light by design: 3PL partners deliver, fintech partners provide BNPL credit.
8 · LemFi (Nigeria)	Fintech, cross-border payments and remittances for the African diaspora in Europe and North America. Equity-funded payments business; added credit products through its 2025 acquisition of Pillar.
9 · Earthbond (Nigeria)	Fintech, embedded asset financing (solar credit marketplace). Often tagged “climate tech”, but the business is credit origination for partner lenders.

Where we looked: nine cases in four home markets, plus Autogirl's move into Ghana

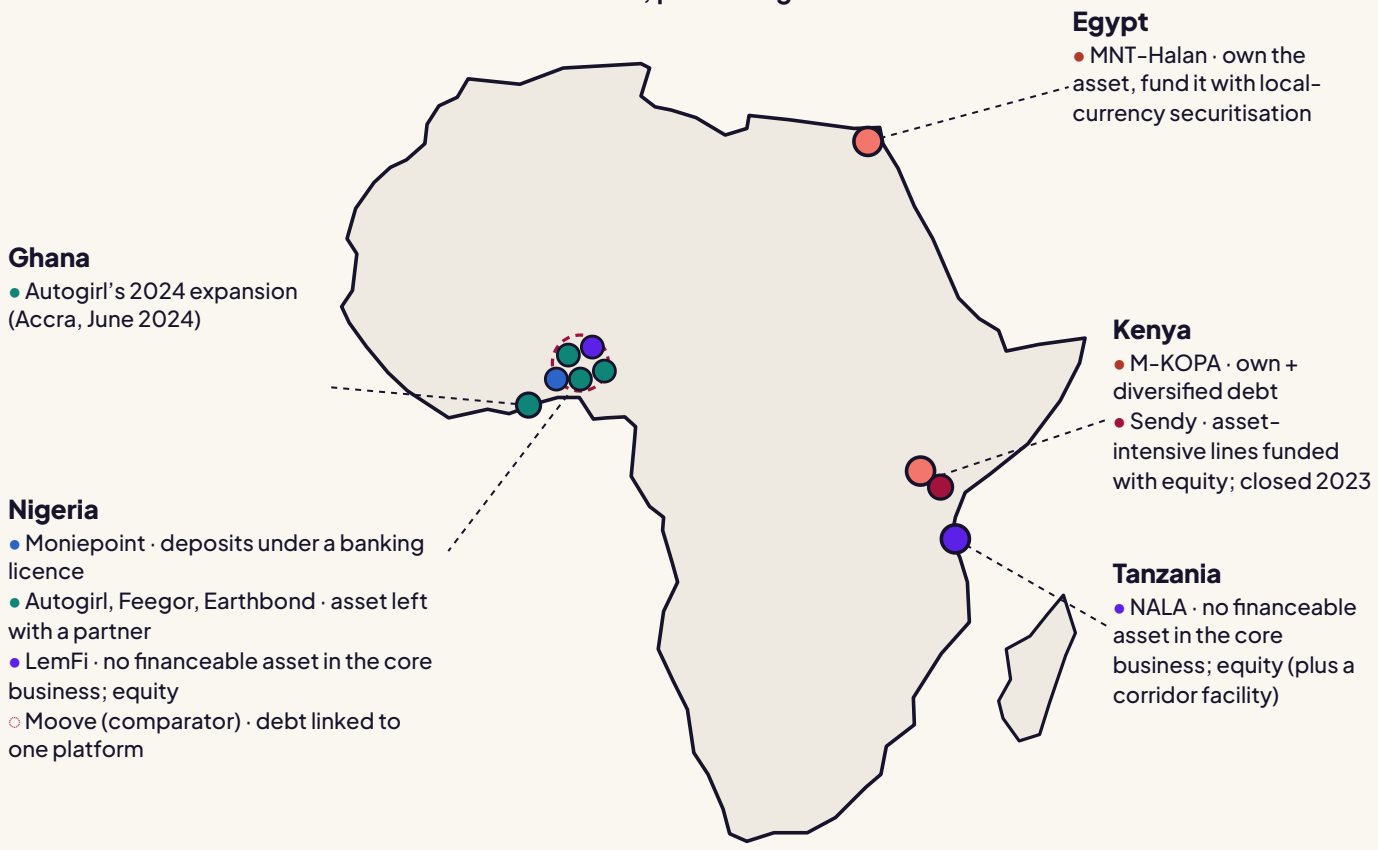


Figure 4 Pins sit in each company's home market, coloured by funding route (see the key on page 11). The dashed ring marks Moove, read alongside the nine cases, not one of them. Sources: case studies, Sections 04–05.

Analytical dimensions

Each case is assessed on the same seven dimensions where evidence allows. The dimensions are not equally relevant or equally documented for every company; where information is undisclosed, the case says so rather than inferring it. All seven are read through one organising question, who carries the asset and its risk (see the next page).

DIMENSION	QUESTIONS ASKED OF EVERY CASE
Funding timing	When did the founder raise, and why then? What was the business condition, and were raises deliberately delayed or accelerated?
Instrument choice	Equity, debt, grant or blended. How did the mix evolve across stages, and why?
Investor selection	Who did the founder choose to take money from, and who did they turn down? What does the investor mix suggest about the founder's strategic intent?
Dilution management	How did founders protect ownership through rounds? What dilution patterns emerge, and how do they compare across geographies?
Follow-on funding	Ability to raise a subsequent round, as a market-validated signal of model quality and investor confidence.
Debt vs. equity decisions	When did founders shift between debt and equity, and what triggered the shift?
Decline or delay decisions	Documented cases where founders rejected capital, delayed a raise or took a smaller round than available, and why.

One organising question

The seven dimensions are read through one question: who carries the asset and its risk? Timing, instrument choice, dilution and investor selection matter here mainly for how they answer it, as the figure shows. The case write-ups keep the seven headings so that cases can be compared, and each case opener names its answer under “Who carries the asset”.

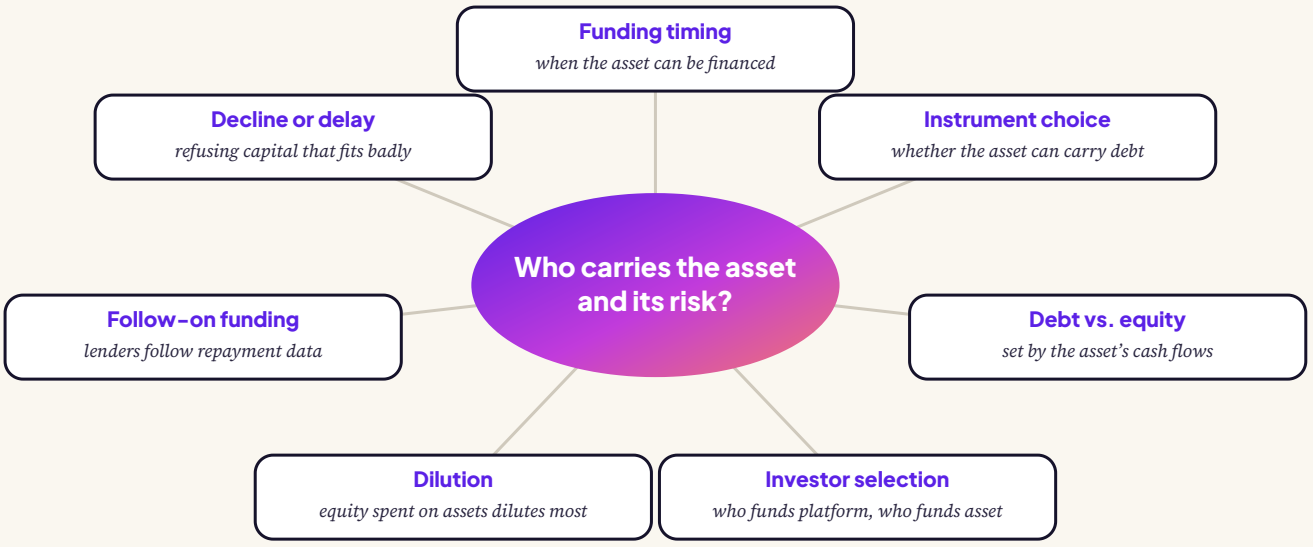


Figure 5 How each dimension connects to the organising question. Source: Sections 02 and 07.

Unit of analysis and how the cases are used

The unit of analysis is the company. Each case follows one company’s financing decisions from founding to the latest public information. Where a founder’s earlier venture shaped those decisions, as Vasiti did for Feegor, it is described as background and is not assessed against the framework.

The mix of outcomes is deliberate. The five scaled companies show which structures held up at scale; Sendy shows a structure that did not; Moove is read alongside the cases as a comparator. The three early-stage companies are comparators, not tests of success: their outcomes are open, so they show how founders design around an asset before they can finance it. Funding timing, instrument choice and investor selection apply fully at their stage; dilution, follow-on funding and debt-versus-equity decisions are thinly documented and are reported as such. Currency and treasury are not a separate dimension: they are assessed within instrument choice and debt versus equity, because the currency of a liability matters in relation to the asset it funds, and the framework adds a currency row to its stage guidance (Section 7).

WHAT READERS SHOULD NOT GENERALISE FROM THIS SAMPLE

- That a financing choice caused an outcome: the cases show associations, and every outcome also reflects execution, markets and timing.
- That the scaled companies are typical: they were chosen partly for their strong public records, and only one failure is examined in full.
- That partner models succeed: the early-stage outcomes are not yet known.
- That the patterns hold beyond fintech and logistics, or outside Egypt, Kenya, Nigeria, Tanzania and Ghana.

Data sources

Each case draws on publicly available sources: company announcements and blogs, investor and DFI press releases, listing disclosures where available (notably for MNT-Halan's EGX offering), founder interviews and commentary published in the press, reporting by outlets such as TechCabal, TechCrunch, Rest of World, Enterprise AM and Techpoint Africa, and funding databases (Crunchbase, Tracxn, Briter, Africa: The Big Deal). Material claims are cited in the text by outlet and date, and sources are listed by case in the bibliography.

Evidence standards

The cases distinguish four kinds of statement: documented facts, such as round sizes, investors and dates reported by the company, its investors or regulators; founder-reported explanations, such as why a round was raised or a product line closed, which are attributed to the founder; the authors' interpretations, signalled by language such as "suggests" or "is consistent with"; and open questions, which are stated as such. Where secondary sources disagree, the case reports the range or the better-sourced figure. Events from mid-2026 onward rely on press reports close to the submission date and may be revised.

Limitations

The study has five main limitations. First, selection bias: cases were chosen partly for the strength of their public record, which favours companies that raised and announced institutional capital, and only one failed company is examined in full. Second, disclosure is uneven: ownership and dilution are rarely public, debt terms are seldom disclosed, and the early-stage cases rely heavily on founder interviews given to the press. Third, the companies differ widely in maturity, from pre-seed startups to a lender preparing to list, so stage effects and strategy effects are hard to separate. Fourth, the cases span different markets, regulators and currencies, which limits direct comparison. Fifth, applying one framework to businesses as different as a deposit-taking bank, a remittance app and a car-rental marketplace means some dimensions carry more weight in some cases than in others. The findings are therefore patterns and plausible explanations, not estimates of causal effects, and they are not representative of African startups generally.

The nine cases by stage, and the comparator read alongside them

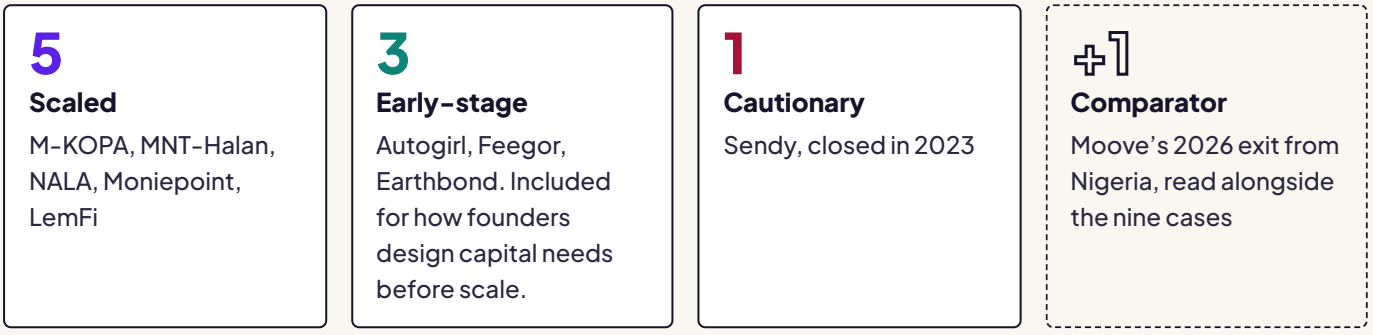


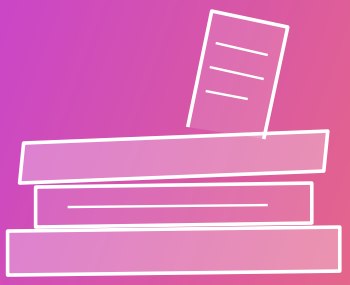
Figure 6 Case mix used in the cross-case synthesis. Source: Section 06.

HOW TO READ THE COLOURS IN THIS REPORT

- Equity
- Debt / securitisation
- Deposits
- Partner-held asset
- Grants and prizes
- Cautionary outcome
- Revenue / own funds
- Comparator (Moove)

SECTION 03

03



Literature review

Capital strategy in venture-backed companies (global)

Since Sahlman (1990) and Gompers (1995), venture finance research has treated staged capital as a response to information asymmetry: investors release tranches as milestones are met, limiting downside while keeping the option to back winners. Hellmann and Puri (2000) showed that venture backing reshapes product-market strategy, and Kaplan and Strömberg (2003) showed how preferred-equity control rights preserve investor leverage. The resulting model (equity rounds, tranched disbursements, board seats, liquidation preferences) became Silicon Valley's template and has been widely adopted in emerging markets with few adaptations.

Much of this literature models the founder as a recipient of investor-designed contracts rather than as a strategic actor choosing among instruments. Wasserman's (2012) "rich versus king" trade-off between financial return and control remains largely descriptive, while Ewens, Nanda and Rhodes-Kropf (2018) showed cheaper experimentation shifting venture investing toward smaller, staged bets, and SAFEs and revenue-based financing have widened founders' options in mature markets. The corporate-finance literature on capital structure, notably the pecking-order view that firms prefer internal funds, then debt, then equity (Myers and Majluf, 1984), bears directly on the debt-versus-equity choices examined here, although it was developed for established firms rather than startups. The normative question for founders remains less developed: given the available instruments, what does good capital strategy look like? Practitioner writing, including investor blogs and founder memoirs such as Horowitz (2014) and Hastings and Meyer (2020), offers insight but rarely compares cases systematically. This capstone applies one framework across nine cases to produce comparative, if exploratory, findings rather than isolated anecdotes.

> *The normative question for founders remains less developed: given the available instruments, what does good capital strategy look like?*

The African VC context: what makes it different

Three structural features set Africa apart.

1 The first, and most consequential, is **currency risk**. In Egypt, Nigeria and Kenya, three of the continent's four largest venture markets alongside South Africa, and in Ghana, many founders earn in local currency while raising or borrowing in dollars. Devaluation then raises the local cost of dollar liabilities and lowers the dollar value of revenue and equity. The Egyptian pound (EGP) lost more than 80% of its value against the US dollar (USD) between 2016 and 2024; the Nigerian naira (NGN) lost roughly two-thirds in 2023–2024 alone. Dollar equity carries no repayment obligation, so the mismatch bites hardest where dollar debt funds local-currency assets; heavy dollar equity still exposes a company to valuation losses after a devaluation, while too little capital leaves a capital-intensive business under-resourced.

2 The second is **the weight of development finance institutions (DFIs)**, both as direct investors and lenders and as limited partners (LPs) in African VC funds. The IFC, BII, EBRD, EIB, FMO, KfW and Proparco play a larger role in African venture and growth finance than in most developed markets, with return expectations, governance requirements and mandates that differ from commercial VC. For founders, DFI capital can signal development credibility, unlock blended finance and fund thin-margin or long-payback models, at the cost of slower processes, impact reporting and governance requirements.

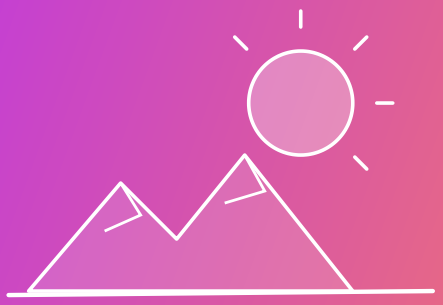
3 The third is **thin exit infrastructure**. Public markets for African tech remain shallow, and global strategic acquisitions, such as Stripe's purchase of Paystack and Network International's of DPO Group (both 2020), are exceptions. Founders should plan for longer times to exit, so capital efficiency and profitability carry more weight than in the "grow fast, exit in seven to ten years" model associated with Silicon Valley: raising too much, too fast can strand a company if the expected exit does not materialise.

Gaps in the existing literature

Ecosystem research from Africa: The Big Deal, AVCA, Partech and Briter tracks funding volumes, instruments, sectors and geographies, while journalist-led profiles by TechCabal, Rest of World and Sifted document individual capital stories. Practitioner commentary from investors and founders adds lessons, usually from a single company's experience. We found few published studies that compare founder financing decisions across African companies using a consistent framework, though our search was not systematic and relevant work may exist in sources we did not review. The contribution of this capstone is therefore incremental: it applies one seven-dimension framework to nine companies, separates documented facts from interpretation, and derives a decision framework (Section 7) that can be tested on further cases.

SECTION 04

04



Case studies: East & North Africa

GEOGRAPHIES COVERED **Kenya, Egypt, Tanzania**

The four cases below cover East and North Africa. Three meet the success criteria: M-KOPA (asset financing), MNT-Halan (digital lending) and NALA (cross-border payments). The fourth, Sendy, a logistics company that closed in 2023, is the cautionary case. Three regional features shape capital strategy: mobile money dominates East African payments, Egypt has absorbed repeated devaluations since 2016, and DFIs are active in both regions.

1 **M-KOPA**
Kenya · Fintech: asset financing and digital credit
OWN + DIVERSIFIED DEBT 15

2 **MNT-Halan**
Egypt · Fintech with logistics roots: digital lending, payments, e-commerce, delivery
OWN + DIVERSIFIED DEBT 18

3 **NALA**
Tanzania · Fintech: cross-border payments
NO ASSET IN CORE 21

4 **Sendy**
Kenya · Logistics: on-demand delivery, then B2B transport, fulfilment and supply
ASSET LINES + EQUITY 24

CASE 1 · KENYA

M-KOPA

Jesse Moore & Nick Hughes · founded 2011, Nairobi



~$245M equity by May 2023

$300M+ debt facilities by 2023

10M customers

$600M revenue, FY2025

BUSINESS	MAIN INVESTORS	WHO CARRIES THE ASSET	STATUS
Pay-as-you-go smartphones, solar equipment, loans, insurance	Generation IM, Broadscale, Sumitomo (equity); Standard Bank, IFC, FMO, BII (debt)	Own the asset, fund it with diversified debt	First annual profit 2024, maintained 2025; five markets

Why this founder

Former Vodafone executives Jesse Moore and Nick Hughes, the latter one of the architects of M-Pesa, built M-KOPA on one insight: low-income customers can pay for an asset if payments are small, daily and made over mobile money. That made M-KOPA a lender, and it designed its capital structure around that fact from an early stage. It meets the success criteria on revenue scale, multi-country expansion and repeated follow-on funding, and has reported annual profits since 2024 (TechCabal, October 2025; FF News, October 2026).

Funding journey

2011–2014 GRANT EQUITY Early grant and impact equity (amounts not itemised in the sources reviewed) fund product development and the first Kenyan solar home system pilots while the pay-as-you-go model is proven on small volumes.

2015–2021 EQUITY DEBT Impact equity, including from British International Investment (formerly CDC), alongside working-capital debt from local and international lenders, which reached a little over $100M before 2023 (TechCrunch, May 2023), so customer devices are financed largely outside the equity base.

March 2022 EQUITY M-KOPA raises a $75M equity round led by Generation Investment Management and Broadscale Group.

May 2023 DEBT EQUITY More than $250M raised, the company's largest raise to date: more than $200M of sustainability-linked debt, half provided by Standard Bank, with IFC, FMO, BII, Lion's Head, Mirova SunFunder and Nithio; and $55M of equity led by Sumitomo Corporation, a Japanese trading house, with $36.5M; Blue Haven Initiative, Lightrock, Broadscale and Latitude participated (TechCrunch, May 2023).

2024–2026 REVENUE First annual profit in 2024 (KES 1.2B, ~$9.2M) on revenue of $416M, up 66% (TechCabal, October 2025). FY2025 revenue of $600M, up 45%, with profitability maintained; 10 million customers by October 2026 (FF News, October 2026).

Figure 7 M-KOPA's funding journey, coloured by instrument. Sources: TechCrunch (May 2023); TechCabal (Oct 2025); FF News (Oct 2026).

ANALYSIS ACROSS FRAMEWORK DIMENSIONS

Instrument choice: funding the book separately from the business

M-KOPA's defining decision is to separate what equity and debt pay for. Equity funds the platform: technology, credit underwriting, market entry and the agent network. Debt funds the receivables, the devices customers pay off over time; in 2023 the company raised more than $200M of debt against $55M of equity. Babajide Duroshola, then General Manager for Nigeria, said it was "very difficult for us to be lending based off equity drawdowns", and described equity as expensive because it means giving up part of the business (TechCabal, May 2023). M-KOPA had extended more than $1B of cumulative credit to over three million customers by May 2023, and about $1.5B by late 2024 (TechCrunch, May 2023; African Business, September 2024). With receivables on debt facilities, each equity dollar supports several dollars of lending. The structure appears to work because repayments are small, frequent and observable, and because financed devices can be locked when customers stop paying, which gives lenders a repayment record to underwrite. Its risks are less visible in public sources: the currency mix of M-KOPA's facilities and its hedging are only partly disclosed. IFC's 2022 loans were offered in local-currency equivalents, up to $50M in dollars or shillings in Kenya and up to $15M in Ugandan shillings (IFC, November 2022), but the currency of most other facilities is not public, and any dollar debt funding shilling or naira receivables would carry the mismatch described in Section 3.

Equity and debt raised, against credit extended (US$, to scale)

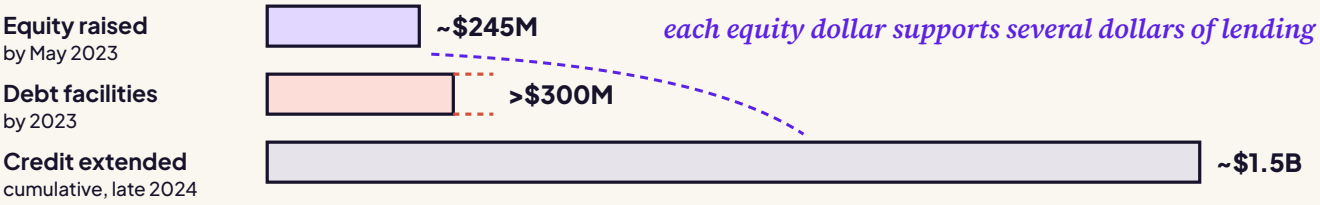


Figure 8 Bars drawn to one scale; the debt bar is a lower bound. Sources: TechCrunch (May 2023); African Business (Sept 2024).

Investor selection: DFIs as lenders, a corporate as the equity anchor

The investor base mirrors the instruments. DFIs (IFC, FMO, BII) act mainly as lenders, where their mandate goes furthest, and Standard Bank provided half of the 2023 facility. Sumitomo Corporation led the 2023 equity round with $36.5M, its first significant fintech-focused investment in Africa, and Lightrock and Broadscale also participated (TechCrunch, May 2023). The 2023 debt was sustainability-linked, tying lender terms to growth in women customers; its pricing is not public, so whether impact lowered M-KOPA's cost of capital cannot be confirmed.

Funding timing: more than a decade of patience

M-KOPA took 13 years to report its first annual profit, moving from solar home systems into smartphones, loans and insurance. It raised repeatedly, in equity rounds of $55M–$75M rather than single very large rounds. Its 2023 raise closed as African venture funding fell sharply, and illustrates an advantage lenders can have in a downturn: debt providers underwrite repayment data as well as growth prospects. It was among the continent's largest raises that year.

Dilution management and follow-on funding

Ownership figures are not public, but raising about $245M of equity while extending around $1.5B of credit indicates that instrument choice, not only valuation, limited dilution. Returning equity investors and repeat DFI lending are consistent with investor confidence through the transition to profitability. No decision to decline or delay capital is documented. In July 2025 M-KOPA was reported to be nearing a close on about $160M of Series F equity, again led by Sumitomo; the company confirmed a raise was under way, but no close has been announced (ImpactAlpha, July 2025).

What made the receivables financeable



Figure 9 The three conditions the case identifies behind M-KOPA's debt capacity. The currency mix of its facilities and its hedging are only partly disclosed. Sources: TechCabal (May 2023); TechCrunch (May 2023).

KEY LESSONS FOR FOUNDERS & INVESTORS

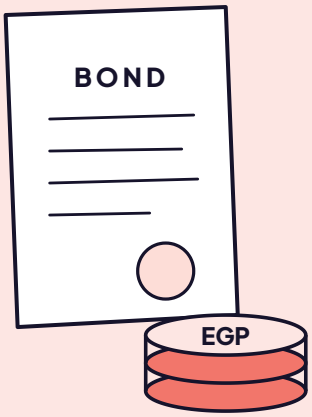
1. Where an asset produces small, predictable and observable repayments, fund it with debt and the platform with equity. A lender that funds its loan book with venture equity dilutes its shareholders every time it grows.
2. Use DFIs where their mandate is strongest: M-KOPA's DFIs took part mainly as lenders in a sustainability-linked facility rather than as equity investors.
3. Debt capacity rests on data and enforcement: daily repayment records and remote device locking appear central to what made M-KOPA's receivables financeable.

> *A lender that funds its loan book with venture equity dilutes its shareholders every time it grows.*

CASE 2 · EGYPT

MNT-Halan

Mounir Nakhla · MNT roots 2010, Halan 2018, merged 2021



$400M+ securitised in 2023

8M+ customers

$15.5B+ disbursed

$1.4B valuation, June 2026

BUSINESS	MAIN INVESTORS	WHO CARRIES THE ASSET	STATUS
Fintech with logistics roots: digital lending, payments, e-commerce and delivery	DPI, Apis, Chimera, IFC, Al Ahly Capital (equity); CIB (securitisation, IPO cornerstone)	Own the asset, fund it with local-currency securitisation	Egyptian arm listed on the EGX, 20 October 2026

Why this founder

Mounir Nakhla raised capital through currency crises and built a repeat securitisation programme in Egypt's domestic debt market to fund his loan book. MNT-Halan also offers a liquidity event, the October 2026 Egyptian Exchange (EGX) listing of a fully secondary 20% stake in its Egyptian arm, and spans both study sectors: Halan began as a ride-hailing and delivery app in Cairo whose fleet became a lending channel after merging with Nakhla's microfinance business, MNT Investments.

Funding journey

2010–2020 MNT Investments, microfinance lending built over a decade under Nakhla; Halan launches in 2018 as a ride-hailing and delivery app in Cairo.

2021 EQUITY Share swap merges MNT Investments and Halan. $120M raised from Development Partners International, Apis Growth Fund II & Lorax Capital Partners, among others.

2023 EQUITY SECURITISATION $400M raised at a valuation of about $1B: about $260M of equity, including about $200M from Abu Dhabi-based Chimera Investments for a stake of roughly 20%, and $140M of securitised bonds across two issuances (Wamda, February 2023). More than $400M securitised over the year in five tranches (Daba Finance, November 2023).

2024 EQUITY $157.7M growth round, including $40M from IFC. Acquires Tam Finans in Turkey; Halan Microfinance Bank receives a licence in Pakistan.

2025–2026 SECURITISATION EQUITY Securitisations continue (EGP 3.4B, ~$71.4M, in October 2025) (WeeTracker, October 2025). June 2026: first close of a round led by Al Ahly Capital, the investment arm of the National Bank of Egypt, at a $1.4B valuation (Wamda, June 2026). October 2026: a fully secondary 20% stake in the Egyptian arm is sold on the EGX at EGP 24.50 a share, raising EGP 7.84B (about $150M), with CIB as a cornerstone investor; the retail tranche is 43.6 times and the institutional tranche 11.2 times oversubscribed, and trading opens on 20 October (Enterprise AM, October 2026; Tech In Africa, October 2026).

Figure 10 MNT-Halan's funding journey, coloured by instrument. Sources: Wamda (Feb 2023; June 2026); WeeTracker (Oct 2025); Daba Finance (Nov 2023); Enterprise AM (Oct 2026); Launch Base Africa (Oct 2026); Tech In Africa (Oct 2026).

ANALYSIS ACROSS FRAMEWORK DIMENSIONS

Instrument choice: local-currency debt for a local-currency book

MNT-Halan lends in Egyptian pounds. Funding that book with dollar capital would create a currency mismatch at the scale of its lending, given the pound's repeated devaluations. Securitisation reduces the mismatch: loans are packaged into rated bonds sold to Egyptian banks and investors, so liabilities are in the same currency as the assets. It also limits dilution: the CEO put the loan book at $650M in November 2023 (Crowdfund Insider, November 2023), funded largely without new equity for each pound lent. Dollar equity funds technology, acquisitions such as Tam Finans in Turkey, and new-market licences. The model depends on conditions specific to Egypt: a domestic securitisation market with willing bank buyers, a regulator that permits non-bank lenders to securitise, and a loan book with enough history to be rated. A founder in a market without these conditions cannot simply copy it.

Matching the currency of the liability to the currency of the asset

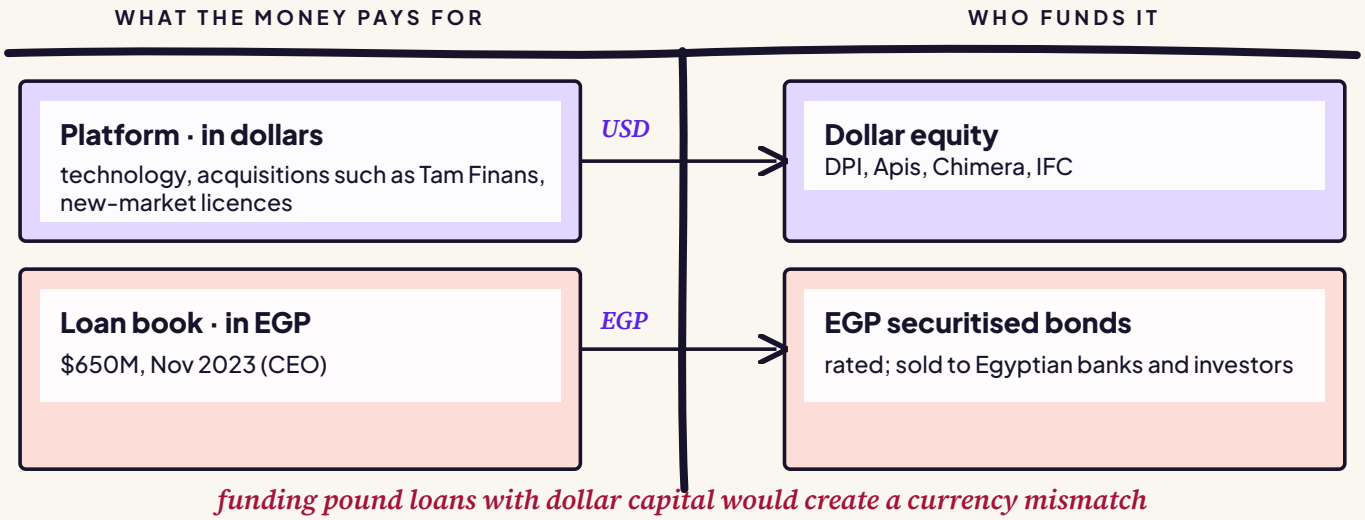


Figure 11 Securitisation lets MNT-Halan fund EGP loans with EGP debt; dollar equity is kept for the platform. It depends on a domestic securitisation market, a permissive regulator and a rated loan history. Sources: Wamda (Feb 2023); WeeTracker (Oct 2025).

Funding timing: raising into a devaluation

The 2023 round closed as the pound fell and many foreign investors were leaving Egypt. One plausible explanation for MNT-Halan's ability to raise is that equity was not funding the loan book, and the book had a performance record investors could diligence; appetite for a rare scaled Egyptian lender probably also mattered. The 2026 listing follows a similar pattern: launched amid low foreign participation on the EGX, with domestic anchors secured first.

Investor selection: from foreign capital to domestic anchors

The investor base has evolved in sequence: Africa-focused private equity (DPI, Apis) and a Gulf investor (Chimera) for early growth, IFC in 2024, then domestic institutions ahead of listing: Al Ahly Capital, the National Bank of Egypt's investment arm and the first commercial bank to take equity in the business, and CIB as cornerstone investor. Local banks already fund MNT-Halan through securitisation; as shareholders, they align the investors who know the loan book with the market where its shares will trade. Whether this sequence was planned from the outset or emerged as foreign capital became scarcer is not documented.

Follow-on funding and liquidity

Because the EGX offering is fully secondary, the parent, MNT Investments B.V., sells existing shares and receives the proceeds, giving its shareholders a route to liquidity. The parent will then subscribe for up to EGP 4B of new shares in the Egyptian arm at the offer price, and half or more of its proceeds are reported to return to the listed company (Enterprise AM, 1 and 6 October 2026). The listing therefore both returns and recycles capital, and listing in Cairo keeps the equity in the same currency as the loan book and its funders. The offering priced at EGP 24.50 a share, raising EGP 7.84B (about $150M) and valuing the listed Egyptian arm at about $770M, a narrower perimeter than the group's $1.4B private valuation; shares rose on debut (Tech In Africa, October 2026; Zawya, October 2026).

How the October 2026 EGX offering both returns and recycles capital



Figure 12 Offering structure as reported; shares began trading on 20 October 2026. Sources: Enterprise AM (1 and 6 Oct 2026); Launch Base Africa (Oct 2026); Tech In Africa (Oct 2026).

Dilution management and decline or delay decisions

Ownership figures are not public, but as with M-KOPA, lending at this scale is funded largely through securitisation rather than equity. No refusal of capital is documented; MNT-Halan raised while many peers could not, which is consistent with a structure that kept it financeable through the funding downturn.

KEY LESSONS FOR FOUNDERS & INVESTORS

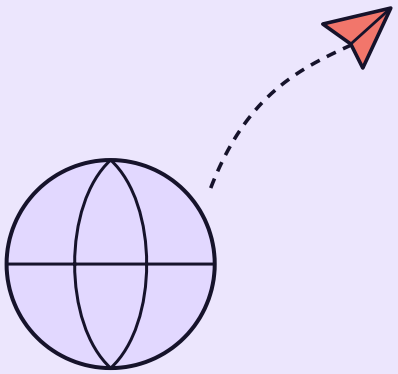
1. Match the currency of the liability to that of the asset where a local debt market allows it: securitisation lets MNT-Halan fund EGP loans with EGP debt.
2. A local debt market is a strategic asset: a repeat securitisation programme gave MNT-Halan funding that was less exposed to venture cycles, though it depends on bank appetite and regulatory approval.
3. A domestic listing can provide liquidity for a company whose funders and assets are already local.

> *MNT-Halan raised while many peers could not, which is consistent with a structure that kept it financeable through the funding downturn.*

CASE 3 · TANZANIA

NALA

Benjamin Fernandes · founded ~2017; pivoted 2021



~$50M equity raised

≤$50M credit facility (2026)

500,000 customers by 2024

Profitable at Series A

BUSINESS	MAIN INVESTORS	WHO CARRIES THE ASSET	STATUS
Cross-border payments: consumer remittances and Rafiki B2B rails	Accel, Amplo, Bessemer, Y Combinator; Acrew Capital, DST Global	Core business on equity; payment float on a facility	Profitable at Series A; 11 African markets (2024), network spanning 16 countries (2026)

Why this founder

Benjamin Fernandes started NALA in Tanzania as a mobile money management app and took it through Y Combinator. In 2021 he pivoted to diaspora remittances, later building Rafiki, NALA's own payment rails. NALA's capital story is one of sequencing: pivot before institutional money, a modest seed on the new model, a Series A only once profitable and, in 2026, debt for a working-capital need that equity is poorly suited to.

Funding journey

2017–2020 EQUITY Mobile money management app in Tanzania; Y Combinator. Small early cheques while the original product was tested.

2021 Pivot to diaspora remittances from the UK, EU and US into Africa.

2022 EQUITY $10M seed from Accel, Amplo, Bessemer Venture Partners and Y Combinator, with angels including the founders of Deel, Robinhood and Monzo.

2023–2024 M-Pesa partnership. Rafiki, NALA's B2B payments platform, is built after partner rails reach failure rates of up to 15% as NALA scales (TechCrunch, March 2024).

July 2024 EQUITY $40M Series A led by Lauren Kolodny of Acrew Capital, with DST Global and Amplo returning, plus Norrsken22, HOF Capital and fintech founders including the co-founders of Chime and Robinhood. NALA reports profitability and positive cash flow over the previous 12 months, revenue up 10x in 12 months and transaction volume up 34x in 20 months (Tech.eu, July 2024).

May 2026 DEBT FACILITY Secures a credit facility of up to $50M from Liquidity via Mars Growth Capital (a Liquidity–MUFG joint venture), starting with a $25M tranche, to pre-fund payment corridors on its stablecoin-based rails and support enterprise clients. NALA says it still holds more than half of the equity raised in 2024 (TechCabal, May 2026).

Figure 13 NALA's funding journey, coloured by instrument. Sources: TechCrunch (Mar 2024); Tech.eu (July 2024); TechCabal (May 2026).

ANALYSIS ACROSS FRAMEWORK DIMENSIONS

Funding timing: pivot first, institutionalise second

One of NALA's most consequential capital decisions was not to raise. The original product solved a real problem in a low-ceiling market, and Fernandes kept the company small, so no large institutional cap table was committed to the old thesis when he pivoted in 2021. Pivots are often capital crises in disguise: investors hold equity in a business that no longer exists as backed, and the founder must raise while managing old expectations. NALA avoided this by raising its $10M seed in 2022, once remittances had traction. The Series A followed the same logic: $40M in July 2024, raised after a year of profitability and with African venture funding well below its 2021–2022 peak. A profitable company can raise to accelerate rather than to survive, which strengthens its negotiating position; the terms NALA obtained are not public. Headcount grew from 7 to more than 100 as capital went into building the organisation (Tech.eu, July 2024).

Instrument choice

NALA's core needs (product, licences, compliance and its own rails) are platform costs with no separable asset to borrow against, and it funded them with equity. Payments do create one balance-sheet need: corridors must be pre-funded, so money is paid out before it is collected. NALA's founder said the company "grew faster than we could handle pre-funding", and in 2026 it took a credit facility of up to $50M for that float, describing it as funding growth rather than replacing equity (TechCabal, May 2026). The facility is a working-capital line tied to payment flows, not a loan book: NALA does not lend to its customers, and how much of the facility has been drawn is not public. The case refines the instrument logic rather than contradicting it: equity for the platform, and debt once a recurring, short-cycle asset (here, payment float) is large and predictable enough to finance.

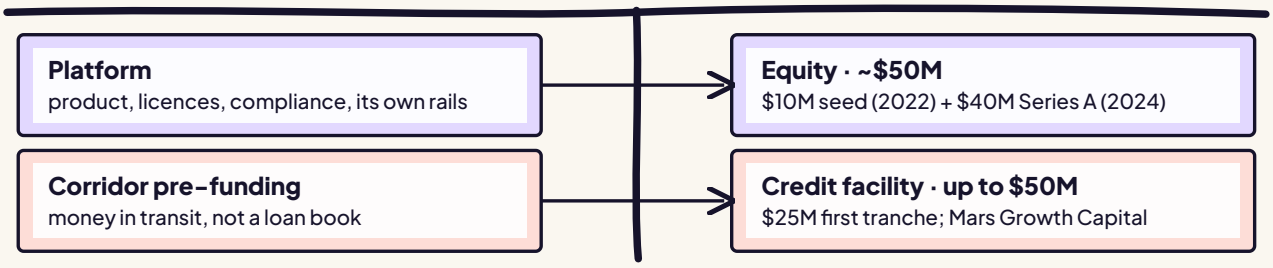


Figure 14 Not a loan book: the 2026 facility is a working-capital line tied to payment flows; how much has been drawn is not public. Sources: Tech.eu (July 2024); TechCabal (May 2026).

Investor selection

NALA's investors suit a global regulated-payments business rather than a Tanzanian startup: Accel, Bessemer and DST bring global fintech experience; angels from Deel, Robinhood, Monzo and Chime have scaled regulated consumer finance in NALA's sending markets; Norrsken22 adds an Africa focus. Hires from Wise and Currencycloud add similar expertise for competing with Wise and Remitly. The 2026 lender, a joint venture with Japan's MUFG Bank, adds a bank-affiliated debt partner suited to financing payment flows.

Dilution management and the Rafiki decision

NALA reached 500,000 customers and profitability having raised about $10M of disclosed institutional equity, little for cross-border payments, and raised its $40M Series A only once profitable, which limited dilution at both stages; actual ownership figures are not public. Using debt for corridor pre-funding in 2026 extends the same discipline. Rafiki reflects it too: NALA built its own rails only once partner failure rates of up to 15% became a measurable reliability problem.

NALA's capital sequence: each instrument matched to the job at the time

2021	2022 · EQUITY	2024 · EQUITY	2026 · DEBT
Pivot	**$10M seed**	**$40M Series A**	**Facility up to $50M**
to diaspora remittances, before a large institutional cap table existed	once remittances had traction	after a year of profitability, in a weak market	for corridor pre-funding, not lending

Figure 15 Summarised from the case timeline and analysis. Sources: Tech.eu (July 2024); TechCabal (May 2026).

KEY LESSONS FOR FOUNDERS & INVESTORS

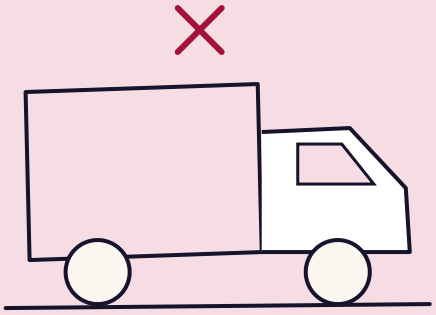
1. Pivot before you institutionalise. NALA pivoted before it had a large institutional cap table, when fewer shareholders had to agree to the change.
2. Raise from strength. NALA's Series A came after profitability, in a weak market, and still attracted a strong syndicate.
3. Instrument choice depends on what the balance sheet must carry, not the sector label: platform costs suit equity, while payment float, once large and predictable, can be financed with debt, as can a lender's loan book.

> *A profitable company can raise to accelerate rather than to survive, which strengthens its negotiating position.*

CASE 4 · KENYA · CAUTIONARY

Sendy

Meshack Alloys, Evanson Biwott, Don Okoth, Malaika Judd · founded 2014–15, Nairobi



~$26.5M
disclosed, from 14 investors

~300
staff in 2022

Aug 2023
ceased operations

BUSINESS	MAIN INVESTORS	WHO CARRIES THE ASSET	STATUS
On-demand delivery, then B2B transport, fulfilment and supply	Safaricom's Spark Fund, Atlantica Ventures, Toyota Tsusho	Asset-intensive lines funded with equity	Ceased operations Aug 2023; administrator appointed Sept 2023

Why this case

Sendy is this study's cautionary case. One of Kenya's best-known logistics startups, with a Japanese strategic investor and multi-country operations, it closed in 2023 after a planned $100M round failed. Its founders built a credible operation. The available evidence suggests its capital strategy contributed to the outcome: the company committed to expansion before the capital was in hand, and moved from an asset-light transport marketplace into fulfilment and supply lines that required fixed costs and working capital, funded with equity. Operating costs, customer pricing and the 2022–2023 funding downturn also played a part (The Star, August 2023).

Funding journey

2015 EQUITY Commercial launch in Kenya as an on-demand delivery app. Investment from Safaricom's Spark Fund.

Nov 2017 EQUITY KES 207.6M (about $2M) equity investment from DOB Equity and CFAO Group, a Toyota Tsusho subsidiary, described by the CEO as growth capital (Business Daily, November 2017).

Oct 2019 EQUITY $2M equity investment from Goodwell Investments (Ventureburn, October 2019).

Jan 2020 EQUITY $20M Series B led by Atlantica Ventures, with Toyota Tsusho Corporation participating (Today Africa, n.d.).

2021–2022 Launches Sendy Fulfilment (warehousing) and Sendy Supply (retail sourcing); expands into Uganda and Nigeria, and takes a minority stake in Côte d'Ivoire's Kamtar with Toyota Tsusho's Mobility 54 (Business Daily, October 2021). Seeks $100M to fund pan-African expansion; the round does not close, beyond a small investment from MOL PLUS. Lays off 10% of staff in July 2022; Sendy Supply shuts in October 2022 with a further 10% cut, and Transport becomes B2B only (Techpoint Africa, August 2023).

2023 CLOSED Suspends on-the-ground operations in Nigeria in February. A key investor withdraws, and talks with new investors depend on a valuation of $40–60M, against an earlier valuation above $80M. Operations cease in August; an administrator is appointed in September (The Star, August 2023; Today Africa, n.d.).

Figure 16 Sendy's funding journey, coloured by instrument. Sources: Business Daily (Nov 2017); Ventureburn (Oct 2019); Today Africa (n.d.); The Star (Aug 2023); Techpoint Africa (Aug 2023).

ANALYSIS ACROSS FRAMEWORK DIMENSIONS

Funding timing: spending ahead of the next round

Sendy raised its $20M Series B in January 2020, weeks before COVID-19 reached Kenya, then expanded across countries and into fulfilment and supply through the 2021 funding peak. The plan relied on a $100M round in 2022, just as venture markets turned; when it did not close, Sendy was carrying a cost base sized for capital it had not raised. That mismatch, more than any single instrument, is the clearest capital-strategy lesson from the case.

Instrument choice: equity funded a shift toward assets

Sendy's original transport business was asset-light: an app coordinating contract drivers who owned their vehicles (Today Africa, n.d.). The capital intensity came later, with warehousing and fulfilment, which carry fixed costs, and a supply business that bought and held retail stock. These lines need working capital and physical assets, which M-KOPA and MNT-Halan fund with debt. Sendy funded them with venture equity, the most expensive capital available, on which a thin-margin logistics business struggles to earn venture returns. Asset-finance or working-capital facilities might have let equity fund the platform alone, but it is not clear such facilities were available on workable terms to a loss-making logistics company in 2021–2022. The lesson is less that Sendy chose the wrong instrument than that it took on asset-intensive lines without a financing route suited to them. Sendy itself exited Nigerian operations as part of a reported shift away from an asset-heavy model (TechCabal, August 2023).

Investor selection: a strategic investor is not a backstop

Toyota Tsusho's participation brought credibility, industry relationships and a market signal, but no public commitment to fund Sendy through a downturn. When the $100M round failed and an investor later withdrew, existing shareholders did not close the gap. A strategic investor's backing is not a guarantee of future support.

Dilution, follow-on funding and decline or delay decisions

Sendy's attempt to raise at a $40–60M valuation in 2023, against an earlier valuation above $80M, shows how quickly bargaining power erodes when a company raises to survive. With hindsight, one alternative was to delay expansion and focus on Kenyan B2B transport, its most established line; whether that line was profitable on its own is not public. Instead, Sendy ran three product lines in four countries on about $26.5M of disclosed funding.

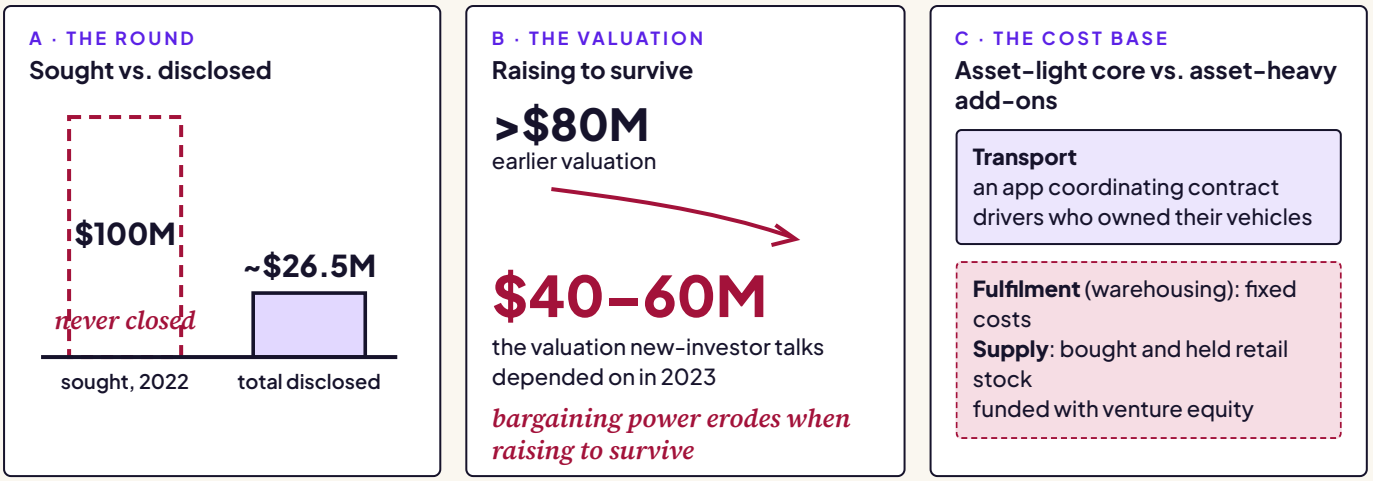


Figure 17 Three views of Sendy's capital position. Sources: The Star (Aug 2023); Today Africa (n.d.); TechCabal (Aug 2023).

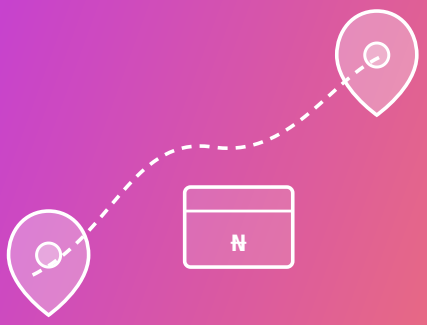
KEY LESSONS FOR FOUNDERS & INVESTORS

1. Never size the cost base to capital you have not raised; Sendy's expansion assumed a $100M round that had not closed.
2. Match the financing route to the asset before adding asset-intensive lines: warehouses, inventory and working capital need asset or working-capital finance, or a partner who carries them, rather than venture equity.
3. A strategic investor brings credibility, not a commitment to fund the next round.
4. Focus before you expand.

> *Never size the cost base to capital you have not raised.*

SECTION 05

05



Case studies: West Africa

GEOGRAPHIES COVERED **Nigeria and Ghana**

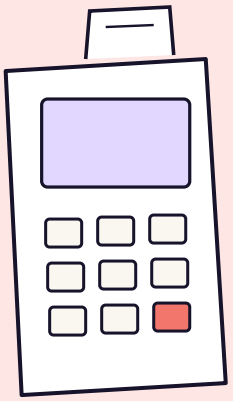
The five case studies below examine founders in West African markets, with Nigeria as the primary anchor. Two are scaled companies (Moniepoint and LemFi) and three are early-stage (Autogirl, Feegor and Earthbond). They apply the same analytical framework as the East and North Africa cases, enabling cross-regional comparison in the synthesis that follows.

5	**Moniepoint** Nigeria · Business payments and banking; licensed microfinance bank	DEPOSITS, BANKING LICENCE	28
6	**Autogirl (Muvment by Autogirl)** Nigeria and Ghana · Peer-to-peer vehicle rental marketplace	PARTNER-HELD ASSET	30
+	**Moove** COMPARATOR Nigeria · Vehicle financing for ride-hailing drivers	DEBT LINKED TO ONE PLATFORM	33
7	**Feegor** Nigeria · B2B wholesale sourcing marketplace	PARTNER-HELD ASSET	34
8	**Earthbond** Nigeria · Solar-asset credit marketplace	PARTNER-HELD ASSET	37
9	**LemFi** Nigeria · Cross-border payments for the diaspora	NO ASSET IN CORE	39

CASE 5 · NIGERIA

Moniepoint

Tosin Eniolorunda & Felix Ike · founded June 2015, Lagos, as TeamApt



>$280M disclosed equity

$1B+ valuation since Oct 2024

~10M active customers

>$250B payments a year

BUSINESS	MAIN INVESTORS	WHO CARRIES THE ASSET	STATUS
Business payments, agency banking and banking services through a licensed microfinance bank	Quantum; Novastar, Lightrock, BII; QED; DPI, Google, Verod; Visa, LeapFrog, IFC, Proparco, Swedfund	Deposits under a banking licence; equity for the platform	Described as operating profitably (Pulse 2.0, Oct 2024)

Why this founder

Tosin Eniolorunda and Felix Ike built Moniepoint over a decade: first as TeamApt, a software provider to Nigerian banks funded from revenue (renamed Moniepoint in January 2023; TechCabal, January 2023); then as an agency banking and business payments network; and later as a licensed microfinance bank serving businesses and individuals. The company took no recorded institutional equity until 2019, four years after founding, and reached a valuation above $1B in 2024 while described as operating profitably. It meets the success criteria on scale, repeated follow-on funding and early international expansion: a UK remittance app launched in 2025 and a 78% stake in a Kenyan microfinance bank, announced in April 2026 (FinTech Futures, April 2026).

Funding journey

2015–2018 REVENUE Revenue-funded, building banking software and integrations for Nigerian banks. No institutional equity is recorded before 2019.

2019 EQUITY $5.5M Series A led by Quantum Capital Partners (TechCrunch, February 2019), ahead of the expansion into merchant and agency payments.

2021–2022 EQUITY Investment from Novastar Ventures, Lightrock and British International Investment (BII), followed in August 2022 by a round of about $50M led by QED Investors, with those investors participating (FT Partners, August 2022).

October 2024 EQUITY $110M Series C led by Development Partners International's African Development Partners III fund, with Google's Africa Investment Fund and Verod Capital joining and Lightrock returning; Moniepoint is valued above $1B (Pulse 2.0, October 2024).

2025 EQUITY Series C extended by $90M to $200M, again led by DPI, with Visa, LeapFrog, IFC, Proparco, Swedfund and Alder Tree joining. Launches MonieWorld, a UK remittance app (Condia, October 2025). A 78% stake in Kenya's Sumac Microfinance Bank follows, announced in April 2026 (FinTech Futures, April 2026).

Figure 18 Moniepoint's funding journey: revenue, then equity across four rounds. Sources: TechCrunch (Feb 2019); FT Partners (Aug 2022); Pulse 2.0 (Oct 2024); Condia (Oct 2025); FinTech Futures (Apr 2026).

ANALYSIS ACROSS FRAMEWORK DIMENSIONS

Funding timing	Moniepoint was revenue-funded for about four years before its 2019 Series A, and raised its largest rounds (2022 and 2024–2025) after reporting rapid growth and, by 2024, profitability. Whether the four-year gap reflects a deliberate refusal of earlier capital or limited investor interest in an enterprise-software business is not documented.
Instrument choice	Revenue, then equity across four rounds. The sources reviewed document no debt facilities, and how POS terminal distribution is financed is not disclosed. As a licensed microfinance bank, Moniepoint can fund merchant lending and float from customer deposits, a source unavailable to the non-bank cases in this study; its deposit and loan-book figures are not public.
Investor selection	The investor base moved from Nigerian and Africa-focused growth investors (Quantum, Novastar) to a global fintech specialist (QED), Africa-focused private equity and DFIs (DPI, BII, IFC, Proparco, Swedfund) and strategic investors (Google, Visa). DFIs and Visa joined at scale rather than early, which is consistent with Moniepoint choosing, or attracting, capital that adds regulatory credibility and payment-network relationships as it becomes a bank.
Dilution management	Founder ownership is not public. Revenue funding until 2019 and later rounds raised from a position of growth are consistent with lower dilution than a company that raised early, but this is an inference, not a measured outcome.
Follow-on funding and debt/equity decisions	Round sizes have grown from $5.5M in 2019 to a $200M Series C, with returning investors (Lightrock, Novastar, BII, Verod, Google) in later rounds, a strong follow-on signal. Moniepoint is the clearest example in the set of a third route between equity and wholesale debt: a banking licence, which turns customer deposits into a funding source but brings capital requirements and regulatory supervision.
Decline or delay	No declined offers are documented; the four-year revenue-funded period is the only evidence of delay.

Round sizes (US$M, to scale): the Series C reached $200M with its 2025 extension

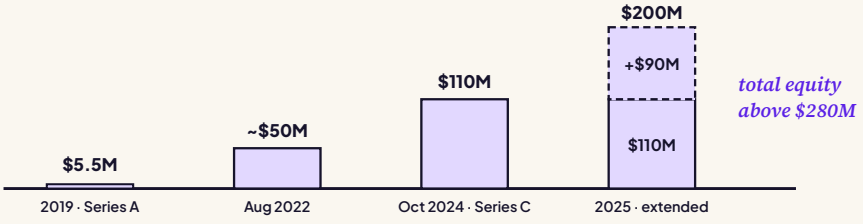


Figure 19 Bars to one scale. Sources: FT Partners (Aug 2022); Pulse 2.0 (Oct 2024); Condia (Oct 2025).

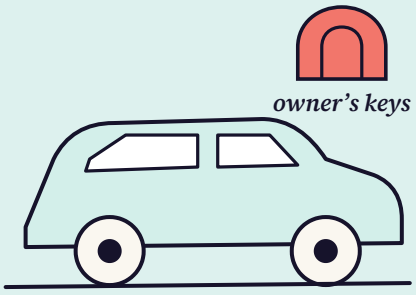
KEY LESSONS FOR FOUNDERS & INVESTORS

1. Revenue funding before venture capital can limit dilution and enforce unit-economic discipline, where the founders start with a revenue-generating product.
2. Float and lending need a funding source matched to them: deposits for a licensed bank, debt for a non-bank lender. Equity is best reserved for technology and expansion.
3. DFI and growth private equity partners can add regulatory credibility as a fintech becomes a regulated bank, though their governance and reporting requirements add cost.

CASE 6 · NIGERIA & GHANA

Autogirl

Chinazom Arinze · founded 2019, Lagos · now Muvment by Autogirl



12,000+ rides by 2024 · **3,000+** customers · **$530,000+** paid out to car owners · **6** cities, 2 countries

BUSINESS	MAIN INVESTORS	WHO CARRIES THE ASSET	STATUS
Peer-to-peer vehicle rentals: chauffeured and self-drive cars, with boat and jet rentals on request	No institutional round; GET Accelerated (₦10M) and Grey's UpGreyed Her ($2,000) grants; Seedstars	Leave the asset with a partner: owners carry the fleet	Lagos, Abuja, Benin City, Enugu, Port Harcourt, Accra; Prado offer unresolved

Why this founder

Chinazom Arinze started Autogirl with no capital. As a law student, she sold cars on commission, flipped her first car with the proceeds and organised campus-to-Lagos rides. Car trading tied up too much cash for too little margin, so she moved into rentals, matching corporate clients who needed cars for three to twelve months with private cars sitting idle between commutes: owners list vehicles, and Autogirl supplies customers, drivers and verification. By her account, revenue covered all staff costs by 2022 with no outside investor (Nairametrics, June 2022), and the company has since entered Ghana. Because owners finance the fleet, the model does the work capital does elsewhere, making Autogirl a foil to Sendy and to Moove, the Lagos-founded vehicle financier that announced the end of its Nigerian operations in October 2026, a month after Uber left the market (Nairametrics, October 2026).

Funding journey

2018–2019 REVENUE Arinze sells cars for dealers on commission and flips her first vehicle with the proceeds. Autogirl is formally registered in 2019 as a dealership and rental business.

2020–2022 OWNERS' CARS Pivot to peer-to-peer rentals, run on calls, WhatsApp and Google Sheets. By June 2022, revenue covers payroll for seven staff with no outside investor; a first seed round is planned.

2023 Around 3,000 trips completed and roughly 123 corporate clients served. Free driver-training programme for women launched.

2024 GRANT Operations rebuilt as the Muvment platform with live booking and owner dashboards. 12,000+ rides; $530,000+ paid to owners (TechCabal, January 2026). $2,000 UpGreyed Her grant (May); Ghana launch (June); GET Accelerated 2024 cohort; Seedstars accelerator.

January 2025 GRANT Named one of five GET Accelerated startups to receive an additional ₦10M in equity-free funding.

2025–2026 LOSS Absorbs a ₦20M (~$14,000) loss on an uninsured self-drive crash; makes verified comprehensive insurance a listing condition (TechCabal, January 2026). Targets Ghana profitability in 2026, eyes Kenya, Côte d'Ivoire and Benin, and lists electric vehicles.

2024–2026 (date unconfirmed) PRADO OFFER · UNRESOLVED Prado investment offer reported, built around Autogirl's strongest rental category. Company marketing says a Prado can earn about ₦100,000 a day and up to ₦30M a year in gross rental income; the source does not state occupancy, costs or contractual terms (Muvment by Autogirl, July 2026).

Figure 20 Autogirl's funding journey. Sources: Nairametrics (June 2022); TechCabal (Nov 2023; Jan 2025; Jan 2026); ThisDay (May 2024); Muvment by Autogirl (July 2026).

ANALYSIS ACROSS FRAMEWORK DIMENSIONS

Funding timing. Autogirl has gone roughly seven years without a disclosed institutional round. Arinze planned a seed round in 2022, but we found no record of it closing; the 2022–2024 funding downturn and cooling investor appetite for Nigerian mobility may have contributed. The company stayed largely revenue-funded through its Ghana expansion. Whether the delay was a choice or a round that failed to close is not public.

Instrument choice and debt vs. equity. Autogirl's main financing instrument is its marketplace: owners carry the vehicles, and by 2024 had received more than $530,000 from an asset base Autogirl never financed (TechCabal, January 2026). Moove offers a contrast. It financed ride-hailing drivers' cars, with repayment linked to their platform earnings, and announced the end of its Nigerian operations about a month after Uber left Nigeria in September 2026, transferring vehicles valued at about ₦35bn to customers at no further cost (Nairametrics, October 2026; Nation Africa, 2026). Moove gave no reason, drivers could still work on other platforms such as Bolt, and Moove continues to raise capital elsewhere, so the link to Uber's exit is a plausible explanation rather than an established cause. Autogirl had no fleet debt to unwind. Risk remains: a ₦20M crash showed that when an owner's insurance fails, Autogirl becomes the insurer of last resort. Verified insurance, guarantors and tracker-backed KYC now do the work a reserve or debt facility would do elsewhere.

Owners carry the fleet; contracts carry the risk

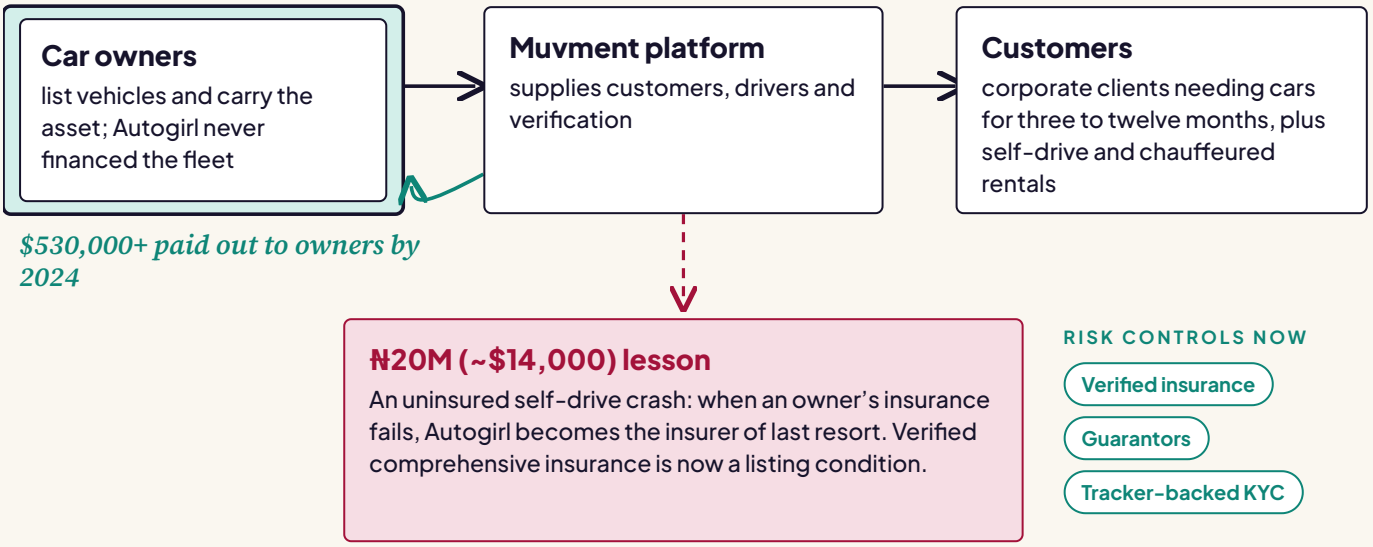


Figure 21 Autogirl's asset-light model moves fleet risk to owners and contracts, not off the map. Sources: TechCabal (Nov 2023; Jan 2026); CNN (Sept 2024).

COMPANY-REPORTED

Company materials for the Prado investment offer cite 520+ vehicles, 20,000+ rentals and ₦2B+ paid to owners, and the company website cites 70,000+ rides; these figures are company-reported and use different bases.

> *Asset-light moves risk; it does not remove it.*

Prado investment offer (unresolved). Company materials describe a Prado investment opportunity that raises outside capital on the strength of Prado rental returns. Its classification cannot be established from public sources, so this study does not treat it as equity. Classification depends on structure: shares in Autogirl would make it dilutive equity; investor-owned vehicles managed by Autogirl would make it off-balance-sheet asset capital; a promised fixed return would make it debt-like whatever the label. Company marketing to car owners describes earnings of up to ₦30M a year as "guaranteed" (Muvment by Autogirl, July 2026); if similar language applies to investors, Autogirl would carry the return risk, and a pooled, return-promising scheme may raise questions under the Investments and Securities Act 2025. The amount raised, investor and vehicle numbers, instrument and any return guarantee are not public.

Classifying the Prado offer: who holds title, and who carries the return risk?

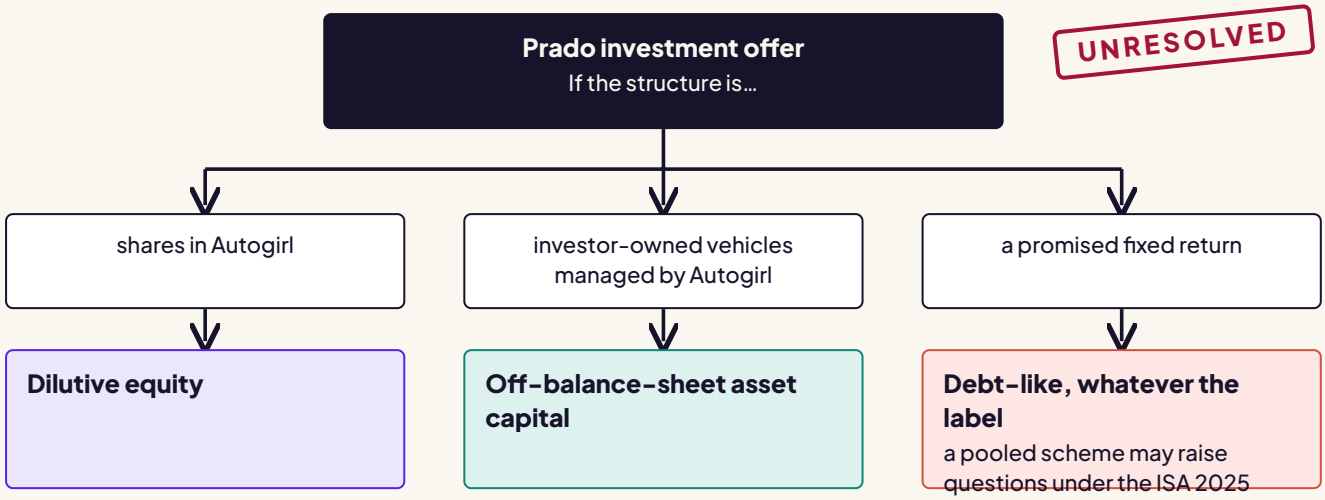


Figure 22 Outcome unresolved: the study does not treat the offer as equity. The amount raised, investor and vehicle numbers, instrument and any return guarantee are not public. Source: Muvment by Autogirl (July 2026).

Investor selection. Disclosed external money has come only from an accelerator programme run by a trust and a grant for women founders, neither taking equity or a board seat. Arinze has said she aims to sell Muvment to a global peer-to-peer platform such as Turo when it enters Africa (TechCabal, January 2026); a moderate-valuation trade sale suits angels, strategic and impact investors better than a venture fund needing a much larger outcome.

Dilution management. The founding team (Arinze and COO Ebuka Arinze) is reported to hold the company in full; whether the Prado offer changes this is not public.

Treasury, FX and follow-on funding. Revenue, costs and owner payouts are in naira and now cedis. With no dollar liabilities, Autogirl avoids the currency mismatch facing dollar-funded peers, but has no hard-currency buffer for cross-border growth. No follow-on institutional funding has been disclosed.

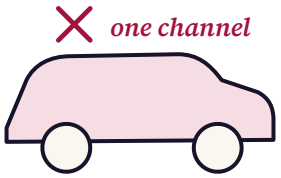
KEY LESSONS FOR FOUNDERS & INVESTORS

1. In mobility, a marketplace that lets owners fund the fleet can substitute for capital: Autogirl entered a second country with no disclosed vehicle financing.
2. Asset-light moves risk; it does not remove it. Insurance, guarantor and KYC terms in the host and rental contracts are the real risk controls and have to be enforced from day one.
3. Asset-linked raises need careful classification. A raise built around one vehicle type can be equity, asset finance or debt depending on who holds title and carries the return risk, which determines how it is accounted for and regulated.

COMPARATOR · NIGERIA

Moove

The Lagos-founded vehicle financier, read alongside the nine cases



BUSINESS	REPAYMENT	WHO CARRIES THE ASSET	STATUS
Financed ride-hailing drivers' cars	Linked to drivers' ride-hailing earnings	Own the asset, fund it with debt, repayment linked to one outside platform	Announced the end of Nigerian operations, Oct 2026

Two exits, one month apart

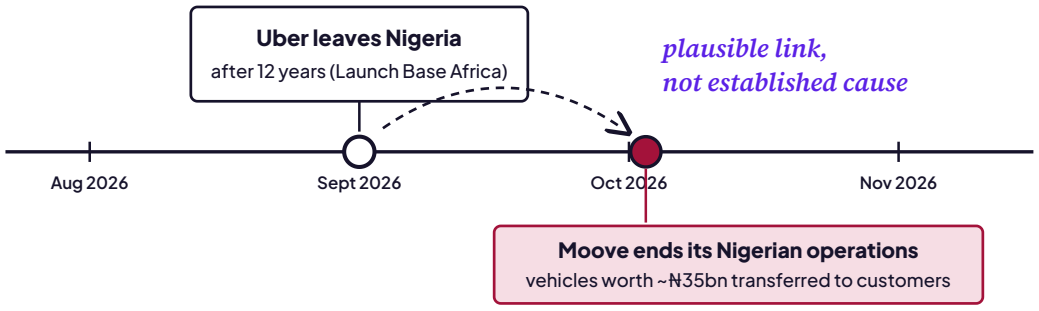


Figure 23 Moove gave no reason, drivers could still work on other platforms such as Bolt, and Moove continues to raise capital elsewhere. Sources: Launch Base Africa (Sept 2026); Nation Africa (2026); Nairametrics (Oct 2026).

Why it is in the study

Moove's 2026 exit from Nigeria is used as a comparator rather than a full case, because the seven dimensions were not applied to it. It financed ride-hailing drivers' cars, with repayment linked to their platform earnings, and announced the end of its Nigerian operations about a month after Uber left Nigeria in September 2026, transferring vehicles valued at about ₦35bn to customers at no further cost (Nairametrics, October 2026; Nation Africa, 2026). The link to Uber's exit is a plausible explanation rather than an established cause. Autogirl, by contrast, had no fleet debt to unwind.

FROM THE SYNTHESIS (SECTION 06)

Moove suggests a second risk: debt suits a fleet, but repayment tied to one platform's earnings is exposed to that platform's presence in the market, so lender, customer and platform concentration can matter as much as the instrument.

CAUTIONARY CASES AS A MIRROR

Moove used an instrument suited to vehicles, but its Nigerian repayments were linked to ride-hailing earnings, and it left Nigeria a month after Uber did; it gave no reason, and its business elsewhere continues to raise capital.

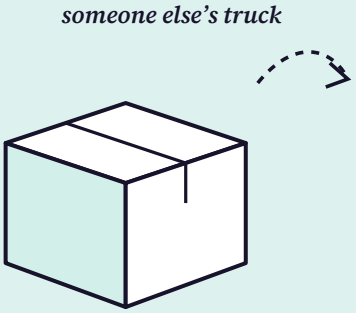
FRAMEWORK RULE (SECTION 07)

Avoid repayments that depend on a single outside platform (Moove).

CASE 7 · NIGERIA

Feegor

Ugonna Ginigeme · founded 2023, Lagos (launch September 2023)



~2,500 businesses (Feb 2024) **6,000** SKUs **3,000+** B2B transactions **₦50M** Hackaholics prize

BUSINESS	MAIN INVESTORS	WHO CARRIES THE ASSET	STATUS
Wholesale sourcing marketplace and SaaS linking SMEs to manufacturers and major suppliers	Friends and family (2023); Wema Bank's Hackaholics 5.0 prize; no institutional VC publicly named	Leave the asset with partners: 3PLs deliver, fintech partners provide BNPL	Pre-seed stage; $500,000 pre-seed sought Feb 2024, no close reported

Why this founder

Ugonna Ginigeme has built marketplaces since studying engineering at the University of Ibadan. His first company, Vasiti, connected student entrepreneurs with customers and was bootstrapped for years until COVID-19 exposed its limits; in 2021 the team repositioned it as retail value-chain infrastructure. Their data highlighted one problem: Nigerian retailers buy through layers of wholesalers, each adding cost, because they cannot easily reach manufacturers. Feegor, launched in 2023 with co-founders including COO Lucy Mbuthia, addresses that problem (Technext, November 2023; The Founder, February 2024). Vasiti is background to the case; the analysis below covers Feegor only. Feegor does not yet meet the success threshold but is included for its logistics design: where well-funded B2B e-commerce players built warehouses and fleets, and several later retrenched (Rest of World, May 2023), Feegor owns none, making it a logistics contrast to Sendy's fulfilment and supply lines.

Funding journey

Before 2021 /asiti, background — REVENUE Ginigeme founds and bootstraps Vasiti, a marketplace for student entrepreneurs, which onboards thousands of businesses and customers.

2021–2022 /asiti, background — COVID-19 exposes Vasiti's limits. The team repositions it as retail value-chain infrastructure and settles on B2B sourcing as the core problem.

2023 — FRIENDS & FAMILY Friends-and-family round funds the team, product and launch. Commercial operations begin in September; within three months more than 1,000 businesses are transacting across 10+ states.

February 2024 — PRE-SEED SOUGHT Raising a $500,000 pre-seed round; the COO reports early VC commitments in what she calls a difficult fundraising year. Around 2,500 businesses and 6,000 SKUs on the platform.

Late 2024 — PRIZE Wins the ₦50M grand prize at Wema Bank's Hackaholics 5.0 from roughly 3,500 applicants, on the strength of its marketplace, sourcing tools and BNPL model.

2025–2026 — The founder credits the prize money and mentorship with letting the platform scale to thousands of SMEs.

Figure 24 Feegor's funding journey. Sources: Technext (Nov 2023); Disrupt Africa (Feb 2024); Techparley Africa (Jan 2025).

ANALYSIS ACROSS FRAMEWORK DIMENSIONS

Logistics model and capital need. Feegor does not buy, store or sell goods. Sellers handle delivery through third-party logistics (3PL) partners, who join the platform as a third user group receiving bulk delivery requests and performance data. Sellers are paid only once goods arrive in good condition, and bear the cost of returns. Ginigeme argues that fulfilment, usually e-commerce's largest cost, is near-negligible for Feegor, and that holding no inventory shields it from inflation. The capital consequence is direct: asset-heavy B2B players funded warehouses, trucks and stock with venture equity, and when funding tightened in 2023, Alerzo shut 14 warehouses and cut 400 staff (Nairametrics, March 2023; Rest of World, May 2023). Feegor's capital need stops at the platform, so friends-and-family money and a ₦50M prize could carry it to market, at the cost of less control over delivery quality, which it manages through escrow and partner data.

A three-sided marketplace that owns no stock, trucks or loan book

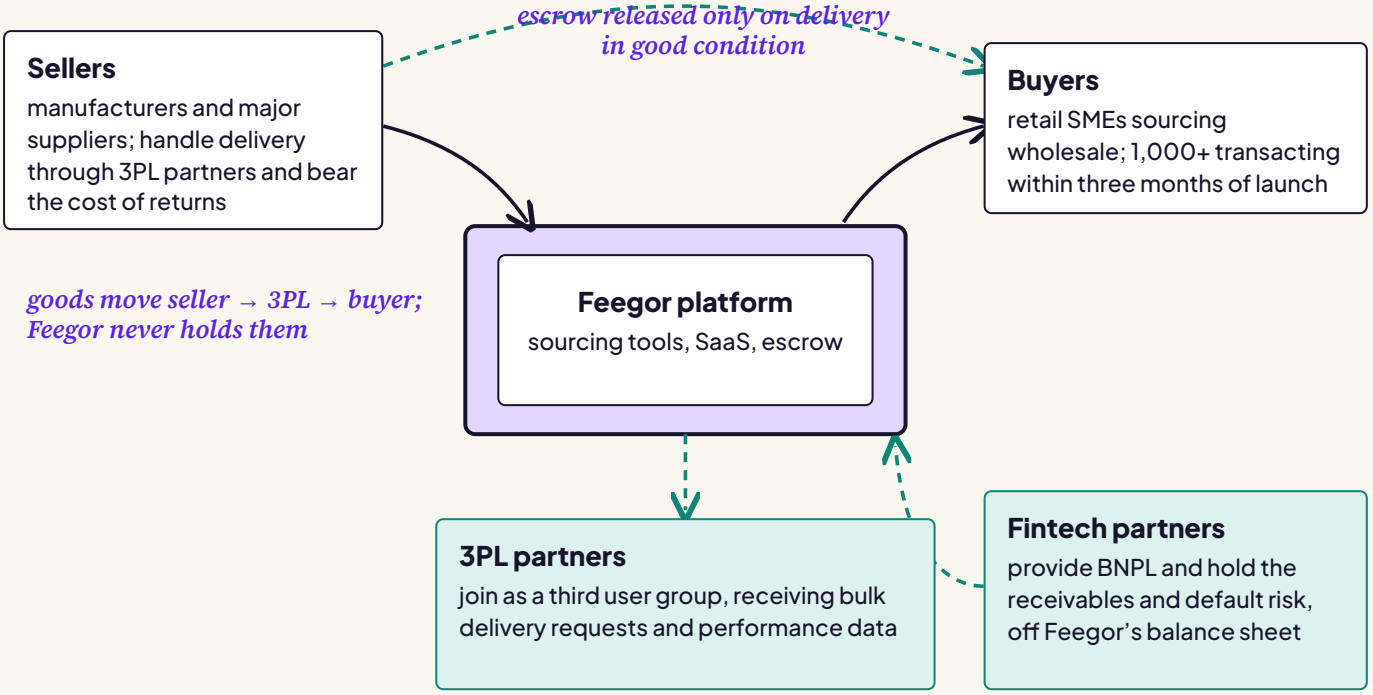


Figure 25 Feegor's three sides plus its credit partners. Escrow and partner data are how it manages delivery quality without owning delivery. Sources: Feegor (n.d.), "Feegor for Logistics Companies" and FAQs; Disrupt Africa (Feb 2024).

Funding timing. The founders raised from friends and family in 2023 and approached VCs in early 2024, a weak market, as the COO acknowledged at the time (Disrupt Africa, February 2024). A $500,000 pre-seed is small next to asset-heavy peers' raises but fits a platform-only cost base. Whether the round closed is not public.

Instrument choice and debt vs. equity. Friends-and-family equity plus non-dilutive prize money. Feegor reports no corporate debt and keeps credit off its balance sheet: BNPL comes from fintech partners, who hold the receivables and default risk. Omnibiz shows one path at scale in B2B commerce, combining $5M of equity with $10M of debt in its 2022 pre-Series A (TechCrunch, August 2022). If Feegor lends in its own name, the framework in Section 7 points to debt for the book once repayment data supports it, although a partner model may remain cheaper.

Investor selection. The first cheques came from people who knew the founders, then from a bank-sponsored competition (Techparley Africa, January 2025). The Wema relationship may be worth more than the ₦50M (roughly $30,000 at late-2024 rates), as a bank is a natural partner for payments, escrow and SME credit. No institutional VC has been publicly named.

Treasury and FX. Revenue from commissions, subscriptions and in-app adverts is in naira, as are costs. No inventory means no stock losses from devaluation, though naira weakness still cuts the dollar value of GMV and of any future valuation. No decision to decline or delay capital is documented.

Nigerian B2B commerce peers named in the case

ASSET-HEAVY

Alerzo

Funded warehouses, trucks and stock; when funding tightened in 2023, shut 14 warehouses and cut 400 staff.

DEBT AT SCALE

Omnibiz

Combined $5M of equity with $10M of debt in its 2022 pre-Series A.

ASSET-LIGHT, STILL HIT

Sabi

An asset-light B2B commerce platform; cut 20% of staff and pivoted in 2025 after raising $38M.

Figure 26 The comparisons the case draws on. Sources: Rest of World (May 2023); TechCrunch (Aug 2022; June 2025).

KEY LESSONS FOR FOUNDERS & INVESTORS

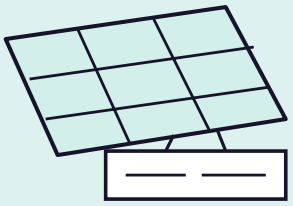
1. Partner for logistics before you own it. Feegor reached thousands of businesses without a warehouse or vehicle, keeping its capital need within reach of friends-and-family and prize funding.
2. If you do not own the trucks, own the trust mechanism: escrow released on delivery and seller-borne returns give Feegor leverage over fulfilment quality.
3. Asset-light is a capital strategy, not a survival guarantee: Sabi, an asset-light B2B commerce platform, cut 20% of staff and pivoted in 2025 after raising $38M (TechCrunch, June 2025), so investors should track repeat orders and take rate.

> *If you do not own the trucks, own the trust mechanism.*

CASE 8 · NIGERIA

Earthbond

Chidalu Onyenso · founded 2022 (launched summer 2022 while at HBS; some press reports cite 2023)



~$405k disclosed, 3 deals

~100 SME solar audits

20+ MWh enabled

1,800+ SME waiting list

BUSINESS
Solar-asset credit marketplace: audits, prequalification, installers, lenders

MAIN INVESTORS
Catalyst Fund, Madica, develoPPP Ventures (BMZ, implemented by GIZ)

WHO CARRIES THE ASSET
Leave the asset with partners: microfinance banks lend

STATUS
Pre-seed stage; 4 microfinance bank partners; Ghana planned

Why this founder

Chidalu Onyenso grew up in New Jersey but stayed connected to Nigeria through annual family visits. After Princeton, she built product and market experience at IBM, Fundera and a Nairobi-based startup, then attended Harvard Business School, where she used nights and a summer grant to build Earthbond. She set out to tackle SME financing in Africa but found unreliable power to be the binding constraint, and founded Earthbond in 2022 as a solar marketplace connecting businesses to power audits, installers and credit providers. It has raised more than $400,000 in grants and venture capital, while partner microfinance banks lend and carry the credit risk.

Funding journey: three cheques from three investor types in nine months (March–December 2024)

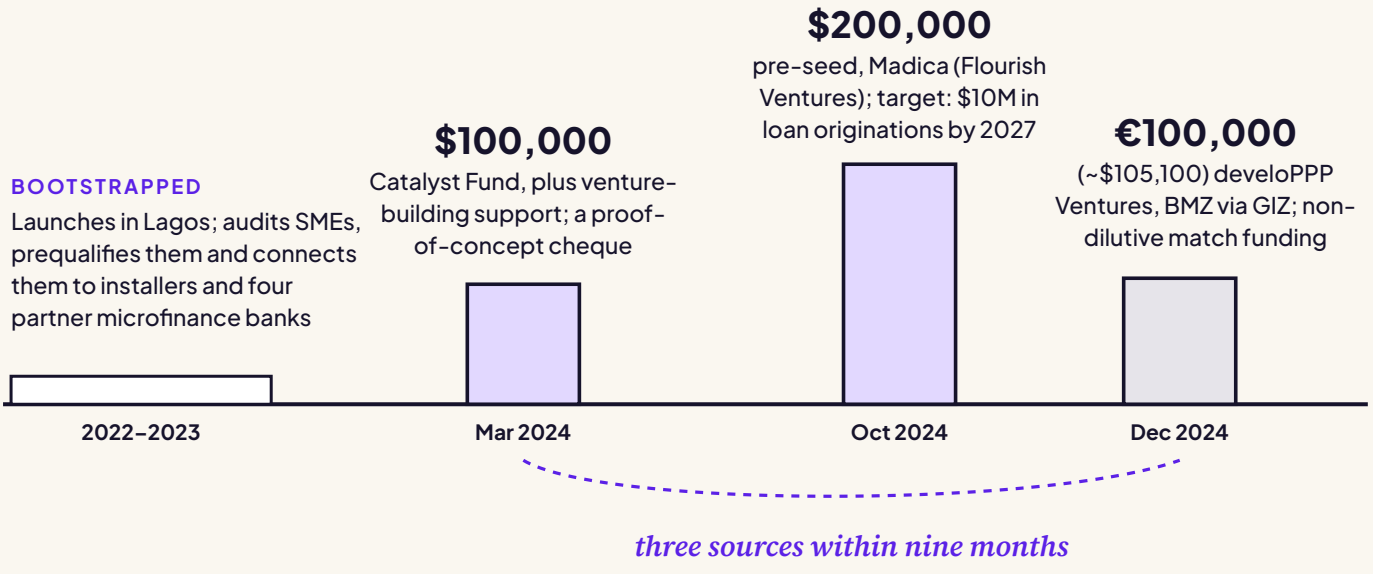


Figure 27 Bars to scale; violet = early-stage cheques (instruments not disclosed), grey = grant. Sources: Launchbase Africa (Mar 2024); TechCabal (Oct 2024); VC4A (Dec 2024).

ANALYSIS ACROSS FRAMEWORK DIMENSIONS

Funding timing	Earthbond's raises coincided with Nigeria's 2023–2024 fuel price rises, which made solar more competitive against diesel generation. It secured funding from Catalyst Fund and Madica after demonstrating proof of concept with SMEs. The sequence is consistent with milestone-based fundraising, though Earthbond's runway before these investments is unknown.
Instrument choice	Earthbond's disclosed financing is a grant and two small early-stage cheques; the instruments behind the Catalyst Fund and Madica investments (for example, SAFEs or priced equity) are not disclosed. It carries no disclosed debt at firm level; blended finance applies only downstream, through its lending partners.
Investor selection	Earthbond's early backers span three types: an accelerator fund (Catalyst Fund), a fintech pre-seed programme (Madica) and a development-agency grant (develoPPP). The mix limits the equity sold, although founder ownership is not disclosed, and leaves no clear lead for a priced round.
Dilution management	Founder dilution is undisclosed. The grant is non-dilutive; whether the two investments have converted into equity is not public.
Follow-on funding and debt/equity decisions	Earthbond has no disclosed priced follow-on, but drew capital from three sources within nine months (March–December 2024), a sign of early institutional interest, though weaker than a lead investor increasing its commitment. It carries no disclosed corporate debt, relying on an embedded-finance model instead. No decision to decline or delay capital is documented.

Where Earthbond's capital sits, and where the loans sit

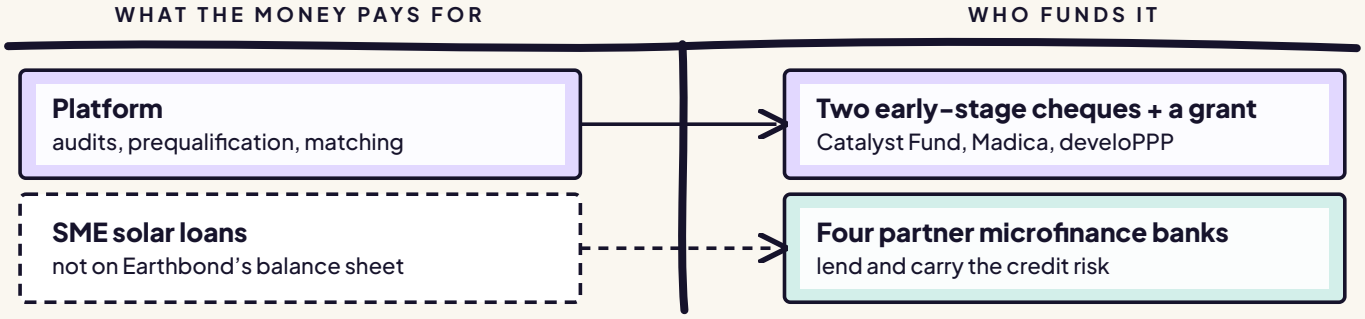


Figure 28 Embedded finance keeps the asset, and its risk, on the partner's balance sheet, at the cost of margin and control. Sources: Empower Africa (May 2025); TechCabal (Oct 2024).

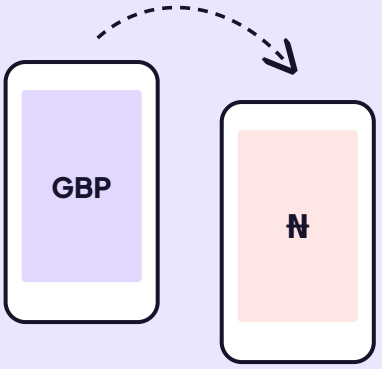
KEY LESSONS FOR FOUNDERS & INVESTORS

1. Layering accelerator, fintech pre-seed and development-agency grant capital can fund a pre-seed company while limiting the equity sold (Earthbond's founder ownership is not disclosed), but is sustainable only if one of these backers, or a new investor, leads the next priced round.
2. Keeping asset-financing risk on a banking partner's balance sheet lets a pre-seed company reach the market without a loan book, but it cedes margin and control over credit decisions to the partner, and growth depends on the partner's appetite to lend.

CASE 9 · NIGERIA

LemFi

Ridwan Olalere & Rian Cochran · founded 2020 as Lemonade Finance



diaspora sends home

~$86M disclosed equity

1M+ customers (~2M by mid-2025)

$1B+ monthly transaction volume

20+ countries

BUSINESS
Cross-border payments, accounts and, from 2025, credit products for immigrant communities in Europe and North America

MAIN INVESTORS
Y Combinator, Highland Europe, Endeavor Catalyst, Left Lane Capital, Palm Drive Capital

WHO CARRIES THE ASSET
Core payments business on equity; credit via a lending partner

STATUS
Series B+; ~$120M if the reported €30M extension closes

Why this founder

Ridwan Olalere left unvested Uber stock in 2020 and invested £19,000 of his own money in a remittance company, drawing on unit economics he had observed at OPay. He has said his first $500,000 pitch deck understated costs and overstated market size, halving the planned 12-month runway; he and co-founder Rian Cochran recovered from those early forecasting errors (TechCabal, August 2025).

Funding journey

2020 OWN FUNDS Founded as Lemonade Finance by Ridwan Olalere and Rian Cochran, building a remittance app for African diaspora communities sending money home.

Summer 2021 Joins Y Combinator (Summer 2021 batch).

November 2021 EQUITY Raises a Seed round (amount not disclosed in open sources).

August 2023 EQUITY Raises a $33M Series A led by Left Lane Capital (FinTech Futures, August 2023).

January 2025 EQUITY $53M Series B led by Highland Europe, with Endeavor Catalyst, Left Lane Capital, Palm Drive Capital and Y Combinator (LemFi, n.d.).

2025 Acquires UK fintech Pillar (June 2025), gaining an alternative credit-scoring model and a UK credit licence, and expands LemFi Credit, a revolving credit line of up to £300 built with lending partner Fintern (FinTech Futures, June 2025). Secures regulatory approvals in Canada and Australia.

2026 EQUITY, REPORTED Reported to be raising a Series B extension of about €30M; LemFi had not commented (FinTech Futures, May 2026).

Figure 29 LemFi's funding journey: priced equity throughout. Sources: FinTech Futures (Aug 2023; June 2025; May 2026); LemFi (n.d.); Y Combinator (n.d.).

ANALYSIS ACROSS FRAMEWORK DIMENSIONS

Funding timing

LemFi took 21 months from seed (November 2021) to Series A (August 2023) and 17 months from Series A to Series B (January 2025). Condia's State of Startup Funding in Africa report puts the current median seed-to-Series A gap at 29 months, up from 18 months (Forbes Africa, May 2026), so LemFi was faster than today's median but not clearly faster than the median when it raised. The traction metrics behind each round are not public.

Months between priced rounds, against the median seed-to-Series A gap

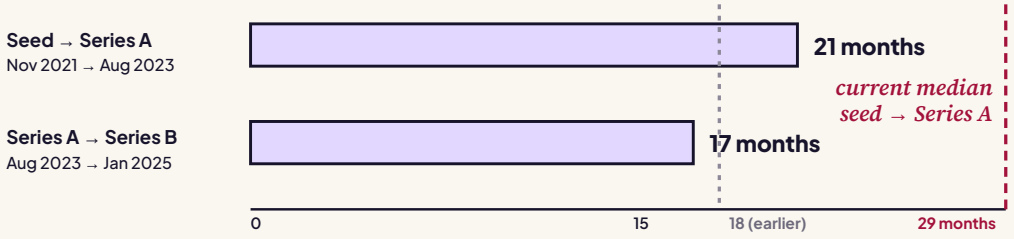


Figure 30 Bars to one scale. The median rose from 18 to 29 months, so LemFi beat today's median but not clearly the median when it raised. Sources: FinTech Futures (Aug 2023); LemFi (n.d.); Forbes Africa (May 2026).

Instrument choice

LemFi's disclosed funding is priced equity across three rounds, plus a reported extension; no venture debt or grants are recorded. That fits its core business: money transfer and accounts are platform costs with no separable asset to borrow against. The 2025 acquisition of Pillar changes the picture at the margin. LemFi Credit gives customers small revolving credit lines, built with a lending partner, and which party carries the loans is not disclosed. An acquisition and an early credit product do not make LemFi a balance-sheet lender, but if lending becomes material and stays on LemFi's books, the framework in Section 7 points to debt or partner funding for that book, as M-KOPA and MNT-Halan use.

Investor selection

For its Series B, LemFi chose Highland Europe, a European growth-stage firm, over a typical Africa-focused investor, aligning its investor base with its customers' markets. Y Combinator is reported to have participated from seed to Series B; whether from conviction or pro-rata rights is unknown.

Dilution management

LemFi's dilution is undisclosed, as is normal for private companies. The progression from small seed rounds to a $53M Series B suggests disciplined fundraising, but without a published cap table this remains an inference.

Follow-on funding and debt/equity decisions

LemFi's strongest signal is three consecutive priced equity rounds, each larger than the last, with no disclosed down round or survival bridge. Whether its equity-only structure to date reflects design or the absence of a borrowing need is an open question; no decision to decline or delay capital is documented.

KEY LESSONS FOR FOUNDERS & INVESTORS

1. A lead investor based in your customers' market (Highland Europe for a company serving the European diaspora) can matter as much as sector expertise.
2. An equity-only structure suits a payments platform, but should be revisited once the company carries float or credit, as NALA did with its corridor facility.

SECTION 06

06

Cross-case synthesis and pattern analysis

This section compares all nine cases: five scaled companies (M-KOPA, MNT-Halan, NALA, Moniepoint, LemFi), three early-stage companies (Autogirl, Feegor, Earthbond) and one cautionary case (Sendy), read alongside Moove's 2026 exit from Nigeria. The early-stage cases show how founders design capital needs before scale; their outcomes are not yet known. The patterns below come from a small, purposive sample and should be read as recurring associations and plausible explanations, not causal findings.

Patterns across geographies · 1. Who owns and finances the asset shapes the capital strategy

The strongest pattern recurs in every market. Any business that needs vehicles, inventory, devices, float or loans must decide whose balance sheet carries them and how they are financed. The nine cases, plus Moove, give five broad answers:

ASSET ROUTE	CASES	OUTCOME
Own the asset, fund it with equity	Sendy (fulfilment and supply lines added to an asset-light transport marketplace)	✗ Closed in 2023 after a planned $100M round failed; costs, pricing and the funding downturn also contributed
Own the asset, fund it with debt, with repayment linked to one outside platform	Moove (vehicles financed against ride-hailing earnings, linked to Uber in Nigeria)	✗ Ended Nigerian operations in October 2026, a month after Uber left; no reason given, and Moove continues to raise capital elsewhere
Own the asset, fund it with diversified debt or deposits	M-KOPA, MNT-Halan (debt and securitisation); Moniepoint (licensed bank: deposits; debt not disclosed)	✓ Scaled; all three profitable or valued above $1B
Leave the asset with a partner	Autogirl (owners), Feegor (3PLs and fintech BNPL), Earthbond (microfinance banks)	◷ Reached the market on revenue, grants and small rounds; outcomes not yet known
No financeable asset in the core business	NALA, LemFi (payments)	✓ Core business equity-funded; both scaled across many markets. Both have since added debt-related activity: NALA a corridor pre-funding facility, LemFi credit products

Figure 31 Five broad answers to "whose balance sheet?", with outcomes as set out in the synthesis. Tick = scaled; clock = outcome not yet known; cross = closed or exited. Source: Sections 04–05.

SECTION 06 · THE CASES SIDE BY SIDE

One-page case comparison

The table sets the ten companies against the organising question. Figures are the disclosed amounts used in the case write-ups; "outcome so far" records what is public, not a judgement that the financing choice caused it.

CASE	WHAT MUST BE FINANCED	WHO CARRIES THE ASSET	CAPITAL SO FAR	CURRENCY POSITION	OUTCOME SO FAR
SCALED					
M-KOPA Kenya	Customer devices and loans	M-KOPA, funded with diversified debt	~$245M equity to May 2023; $300M+ debt facilities	Local-currency revenue; facility currency only partly disclosed	First annual profit 2024; 10M customers
MNT-Halan Egypt	Egyptian-pound loan book	MNT-Halan, funded through EGP securitisation	Equity from DPI, Apis, Chimera, IFC, Al Ahly Capital; $400M+ securitised in 2023	EGP assets funded with EGP debt	20% of Egyptian arm listed on the EGX, Oct 2026
Moniepoint Nigeria	Business and consumer lending	Moniepoint, as a licensed bank funded by deposits	>$280M equity	Naira deposits fund naira lending	$1B+ valuation since Oct 2024
NALA Tanzania	No asset in the core business; corridor float	Equity for the platform; float on a facility up to $50M (2026)	~$50M equity	Much revenue in sterling, euros and dollars	Profitable at Series A (2024)
LemFi Nigeria	No asset in the core business; credit since 2025	Equity; who will carry future loans is open	~$86M disclosed equity; €30M extension reported	Much revenue in sterling, euros and dollars	Series B, Jan 2025; 20+ countries
CAUTIONARY					
Sendy Kenya	Fulfilment, warehousing and supply stock	Sendy, funded with equity	~$26.5M disclosed equity from 14 investors	Not a factor discussed in the case	Closed August 2023
EARLY-STAGE COMPARATORS					
Autogirl Nigeria	Vehicles	Car owners on the platform	Revenue; ₦10M GET Accelerated and $2,000 grants	Naira and cedi revenue; no disclosed debt	Ghana launch 2024; outcome open
Feegor Nigeria	Stock, delivery and BNPL credit	Sellers, 3PL partners and fintech lenders	Friends and family; ₦50M prize; $500,000 pre-seed sought	Naira revenue and costs; no disclosed debt	Outcome open
Earthbond Nigeria	Solar loans to small businesses	Partner microfinance banks	~$405k across three cheques, including a grant	Naira; no firm-level debt disclosed	Outcome open
COMPARATOR, NOT ASSESSED ON THE SEVEN DIMENSIONS					
Moove Nigeria	Vehicles for ride-hailing drivers	Moove, with debt; repayment linked to one platform	Not assessed	Not assessed	Ended Nigerian operations, Oct 2026

Figure 32 The cases compared on the asset question. Dot colours follow the route key on page 11. Sources: case studies, Sections 04–05.

The pattern is clearer against the wider market. Partech reports that African startups raised $4.9B of equity and $1.55B of debt in 2022 (Partech Africa, January 2023), so debt was under a quarter of funding even though many startups finance inventory, devices, vehicles or loans; the data do not show how much equity went to assets specifically. Sendy illustrates the risk of funding asset-intensive lines with equity, though its failure also reflects a cost base sized to an unraised round. Moove suggests a second risk: debt suits a fleet, but repayment tied to one platform's earnings is exposed to that platform's presence in the market, so lender, customer and platform concentration can matter as much as the instrument.

African startup funding, 2022: $6.5B in total

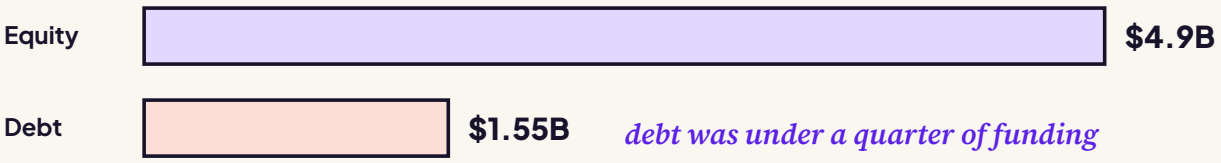


Figure 33 Bars to one scale. The $6.5B was spread across 764 deals: 693 equity and 71 debt, as restated in Partech's 2025 report. Sources: Partech Africa (January 2023; January 2026).

THE PATTERN HAS LIMITS

Owning and debt-financing assets appears to have worked for M-KOPA and MNT-Halan in part because their receivables are small, frequent, observable and in a currency matched to their funders, and because lenders were available. A business with lumpy, seasonal or currency-mismatched cash flows could find debt riskier than equity, since missed repayments can trigger covenant breaches and force a sale or shutdown that equity would not. Leaving assets with partners lowered the capital the early-stage companies needed, but it moved risk rather than removing it (Autogirl's uninsured crash) and ceded margin and control to partners (Earthbond's lenders, Feegor's BNPL providers). Asset-light did not guarantee survival either: Sabi still cut staff and pivoted. Debt-funded ownership is therefore not superior in general; it suits assets whose cash flows can carry it.

> *Debt-funded ownership is not superior in general; it suits assets whose cash flows can carry it.*

PATTERNS ACROSS GEOGRAPHIES, CONTINUED

2

Several founders moved along a sequence as data and lenders became available

Early-stage companies in the sample leave risk with partners, one plausible reason being that they lack the data to price it: fintech partners hold Feegor's BNPL credit, microfinance banks carry Earthbond's loans and owners carry Autogirl's fleet. The scaled lenders, once they had repayment data, carried assets on their own balance sheets funded with debt or deposits: M-KOPA's receivables facilities, MNT-Halan's securitisations, Moniepoint's banking licence. Omnibiz ($5M equity, $10M debt in 2022) shows a similar mix in B2B commerce, and NALA's 2026 corridor facility shows a payments company financing its float with debt once volumes were large and predictable. LemFi's acquisition of Pillar may begin a similar transition, but it is too early to say whether LemFi will carry a material loan book. The sequence is a context-dependent heuristic, not an inevitable progression: some companies will stay with partners because partners finance the asset more cheaply, and moving assets onto the balance sheet makes sense only where lenders will lend on terms the asset's cash flows can support.

3

Raising from strength was associated with stronger syndicates

Founders who raised from strength attracted strong investors: NALA pivoted before taking institutional money and raised its Series A while profitable; Moniepoint was revenue-funded for four years; MNT-Halan raised mid-devaluation while debt funded its loan book. Because terms are rarely public, the study cannot show that these founders obtained better terms, only that they raised in conditions where many peers struggled. LemFi shows speed and strength can coexist, moving from a 2021 seed to a $33M Series A in August 2023 and a $53M Series B in January 2025. Sendy shows the reverse. Autogirl raises an open question: seven years without an institutional round protects ownership, but investors must establish whether capital is deferred by choice or necessity.

4

Investor selection followed the stage, the customer and the exit

Each scaled company's investor base reflects a specific contribution: M-KOPA used DFIs as lenders and Sumitomo as a strategic equity lead; MNT-Halan moved from foreign private equity to Egyptian banks ahead of its Cairo listing; Moniepoint added DFIs and Visa as it became a regulated bank; NALA and LemFi chose leads in their customers' sending markets (Acrew Capital, Highland Europe). Public sources cannot always separate deliberate choice from which investors were willing to invest. The logic holds early on: Feegor's Wema Bank prize may matter more for the banking relationship than for its size, and Autogirl's trade-sale goal points it toward angels and strategic investors.

Figure 34 Patterns two to four, as set out in the synthesis. Pattern one is on page 41.

Disclosed capital by instrument, nine cases (US$M, log scale)

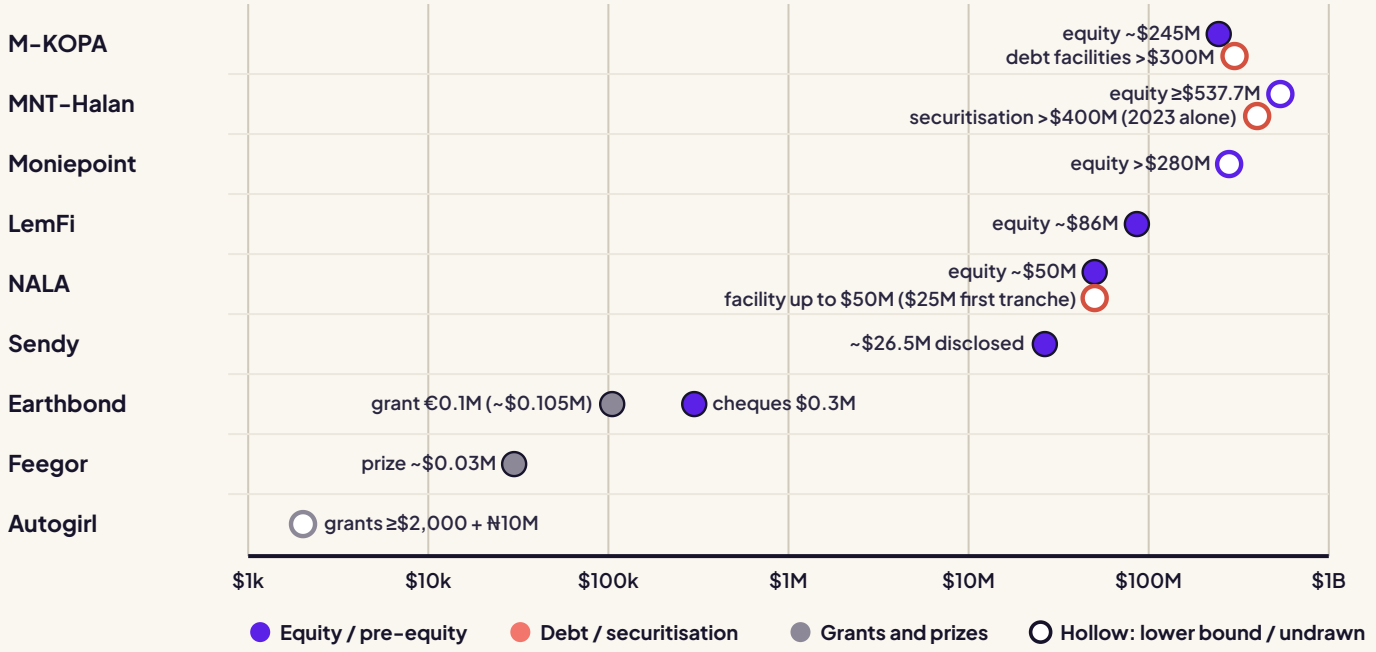


Figure 35 Each marker is a disclosed figure from the case text; MNT-Halan equity sums its three disclosed rounds. Sources: case profiles and timelines, Sections 04–05.

Patterns that differ across regions

Currency shapes capital structure most sharply in Egypt and Nigeria, where founders match liabilities to revenue currency by different routes. MNT-Halan borrows in pounds through securitisation and is listing in Cairo; Moniepoint can fund lending from naira deposits. The Nigerian early-stage companies avoid the mismatch by carrying no debt: Autogirl, Feegor and Earthbond earn and spend in naira with no dollar liabilities, at the cost of a hard-currency buffer for expansion, which matters as Autogirl operates in Ghana and Earthbond plans to. NALA and LemFi stand apart, as much of their revenue originates in sterling, euros and dollars.

Early-stage funding routes also differ. The three Nigerian early-stage companies relied heavily on non-dilutive money: GET Accelerated and Grey's UpGreyed Her grant (Autogirl), Wema Bank's Hackaholics prize (Feegor), and develoPPP alongside Catalyst Fund and Madica (Earthbond). With no early-stage case in the East and North Africa set, the study cannot say whether this reliance is specific to Nigeria. Exit routes differ too: MNT-Halan's EGX listing is the only public-market liquidity event in the set, and Autogirl the only founder with a stated trade-sale goal.

Patterns by sector

In fintech, the balance sheet shapes the instrument. Payments companies funded their core platforms with equity (NALA, LemFi), although NALA has since financed corridor float with debt and LemFi has added credit products. Lenders (M-KOPA, MNT-Halan) raise far more debt than equity. Moniepoint, a licensed bank, sits apart: equity for technology and expansion, with deposits available to fund lending. Early-stage embedded-finance marketplaces (Earthbond) keep lending entirely on partners' books.

Patterns by sector, continued

In logistics, the asset is the hardest part to finance: vehicles, warehouses and inventory tend to yield thinner margins and weaker collateral than a performing loan book. Owning assets has gone badly in this sample: Sendy funded fulfilment and supply lines with equity, Moove's Nigerian fleet finance was linked to one platform, and Nigerian B2B distributor Alerzo closed 14 warehouses and cut 400 jobs in 2023. In each case other factors (pricing, demand, the funding downturn, a partner's market exit) also contributed. Autogirl and Feegor own no vehicles or stock and reached thousands of customers on revenue, grants and a small pre-seed; MNT-Halan turned its delivery fleet into a loan-origination channel. Partner models are no guarantee, however: asset-light Sabi still cut staff and pivoted in 2025, so investors should judge logistics platforms on repeat orders and take rate, not asset-lightness alone.

Patterns by stage

Early stage
The leanest founders layered revenue, grants, prizes and accelerator money and left assets with partners, but none yet has a clear lead for a first priced round.

Growth stage
Scaled founders separated platform from asset capital and built debt relationships early, or raised equity only where the core business had no financeable asset.

Scale
Founders shifted toward investors who can support an exit, as MNT-Halan did with domestic banks ahead of its listing. Sendy reversed this order, expanding before proving one line.

Figure 36 Region, sector and stage in brief: regions differ on currency and early-stage funding routes (page 45); sectors on what the asset is; stages on how it is funded. Source: Section 06.

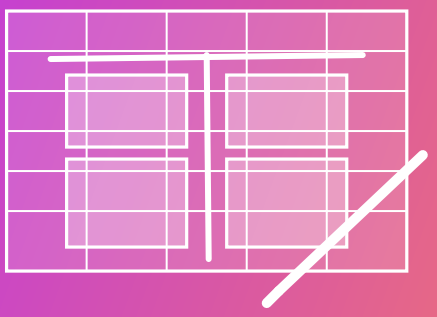
Cautionary cases as a mirror

Sendy and Moove contrast with the successful patterns, though neither outcome has a single cause. Sendy funded asset-intensive lines with equity, built costs ahead of capital and relied on investor support that did not materialise; the valuation it sought fell from above $80M to $40–60M when it raised to survive. Moove used an instrument suited to vehicles, but its Nigerian repayments were linked to ride-hailing earnings, and it left Nigeria a month after Uber did; it gave no reason, and its business elsewhere continues to raise capital. Autogirl's ₦20M uninsured crash adds a third warning: moving an asset off the balance sheet moves the risk without removing it, so partner models work only when risk transfer is contractual and enforced.

> *The lesson running through the study is clearest here: available capital is not necessarily suitable capital, and suitable capital is not always available. Asking what each asset is, whose balance sheet should carry it and which instrument its cash flows can support, before asking how much can be raised, is the clearest difference in this sample between the structures that held up under stress and those that did not, although the sample is too small to show that it caused the difference.*

SECTION 07

07



The African Founder Capital–Strategy Framework

This section presents the capstone's main practical output: a sequence of diagnostic questions and stage-by-stage guidance drawn from the cases, so founders can test financing decisions against the evidence and investors can test whether their capital suits the business. It is a decision aid, not a prescription: each recommendation depends on the conditions noted alongside it, and an instrument that suits a business in principle may be unavailable or uneconomic in a given market.

Step 1: Ask six diagnostic questions

1 What is being financed?
Platform capabilities and operating expenses, or an identifiable asset or receivable such as a loan book, devices, payment float, inventory or vehicles? Usually only the latter can support debt.

2 Who is best placed to own and operate the asset?
The company, a partner that already owns it (car owners, logistics firms), or a lender that can hold it more cheaply?

3 Who should bear the risks?
Credit, commercial, currency, operational, insurance and asset-loss risks can sit with different parties; each allocation should be written into contracts and enforced.

4 What instrument fits?
Weigh cash-flow predictability and seasonality, asset life, utilisation and residual value, repayment duration, debt-service capacity and the consequences of a missed payment, interest cost, collateral, guarantees and covenants, and the currency of revenues against that of liabilities.

5 What conditions must hold first?
A repayment record lenders can underwrite; lenders willing to lend in the right currency, at a price and tenor the asset can bear; and a regulatory route, such as a lending or banking licence or approval to securitise.

6 What happens if a relationship changes?
Test the structure against the loss of a lender, a dominant customer or platform, or a risk-carrying partner, and against a devaluation or a round that fails to close. Weigh, too, the margin and control given up to any partner that finances or operates the asset.

Figure 37 The six diagnostic questions, asked in order before sizing a raise. Steps 2 and 3 follow on pages 48–49. Source: Section 07.

Step 2: Decide who carries the asset and its risks

Before deciding how much to raise, founders should split the capital need in two. Platform capital funds technology, people, licences and market entry, carries venture risk and suits equity. Asset capital funds loan books, devices, float, inventory, vehicles and warehouses. For each asset, the founder chooses among broad routes, which in practice are often combined:

ROUTE	WHEN IT FITS	EVIDENCE	CONDITION
Leave it with a partner	Before the company has the data to price the asset's risk, or where a partner can own or finance the asset more cheaply	Autogirl, Feegor, Earthbond	Enforce the risk transfer in contracts (insurance, guarantors, escrow, title); accept the partner's share of margin and control; avoid dependence on one partner
Own it and fund it with debt	Once repayment or utilisation data supports a lender's credit decision and cash flows are predictable enough to service debt	M-KOPA, MNT-Halan, Omnibiz; NALA (payment float)	Diversify lenders and repayment channels; match debt currency and tenor to the asset; size debt to downside cash flows and covenants (Moove shows the cost of a single repayment channel)
Fund it from deposits under a banking licence	Where the company can obtain a deposit-taking licence and meet its capital requirements	Moniepoint	Accept supervision and capital requirements; deposits fund lending only within prudential limits
Own it and fund it with equity	For small or short-lived needs with no suitable lender, or where cash flows are too uncertain to service debt	Sendy (cautionary)	Equity is usually the most expensive capital for an asset; keep the exposure small and time-limited

Figure 38 The four routes, with the cases that evidence each. Source: Section 07, Step 2.

One test decides the route

One test determines which route a structure follows: who holds title to the asset, and who carries the return risk. In Autogirl's Prado offer, shares would make it equity; investor-owned, Autogirl-managed vehicles would make it off-balance-sheet asset capital; a guaranteed return would make it debt in substance, whatever the label. The same test separates NALA's corridor facility (a working-capital line against payment flows, not a loan book) from lending, and will decide how LemFi's credit products should be financed, depending on whether LemFi or its lending partner carries the loans.



Figure 39 The title-and-return-risk test, applied to Autogirl's Prado offer (see Figure 22). Source: Section 07, Step 2.

Step 3: Apply the stage guidance

The stage bands below are indicative. Revenue thresholds are rough markers; a company's lender access, regulatory status and track record matter more than its revenue band.

Dimension	Early pre-$1M ARR	Growth $1–10M ARR	Scale $10M+ ARR
Timing	Raise to validate, not to scale. Pivot before institutionalising (NALA).	Raise from strength, after proof of unit economics or profitability where possible. Do not size costs to an unraised round (Sendy).	Raise counter-cyclically where the structure allows it (MNT-Halan, M-KOPA in 2023).
Instrument	Revenue, grants, prizes and accelerator money layered for minimal dilution (Autogirl, Feegor, Earthbond).	Equity for the platform; receivables, asset-finance or working-capital facilities for the book or float once lenders will price it (NALA's 2026 facility).	Debt at scale: securitisation, syndicated and sustainability-linked facilities. Equity for M&A and new markets.
Asset route	Partners carry vehicles, stock and credit.	Bring assets onto the balance sheet, funded with debt, once data supports pricing and lenders are available (Omnibiz); otherwise stay with partners.	Own the book where it is cheaper than partner funding; diversify funding sources, currencies and repayment channels.
Investor selection	Investors and sponsors who become partners (Wema Bank for Feegor). Identify the lead for the first priced round before grants run out.	Lead investors based in the customer's market (Highland Europe for LemFi); DFIs as lenders where their mandate is strongest (M-KOPA).	Domestic institutions ahead of a local listing (MNT-Halan); strategic buyers ahead of a trade sale.
Dilution	Keep the cap table small enough to allow a pivot.	Protect ownership through instrument choice, not only through valuation.	Measure dilution against assets financed, not equity raised.
Decline / delay	Delay institutional capital until the model is proven, and be able to show investors the delay is a choice.	Decline capital that funds expansion before one market is profitable.	Decline capital whose return expectations conflict with the likely exit.
Dependency risk	Map every partner the model relies on for supply, credit or demand.	Avoid repayments that depend on a single outside platform (Moove).	Diversify lenders, partners and markets so no single exit or failure halts the business.
Currency	Keep costs and liabilities in the currency of revenue; avoid dollar liabilities against local-currency income.	Borrow in the asset's currency where local lenders exist; price hedging into any dollar facility.	Use local debt markets and listings where available (MNT-Halan).
Liquidity	State the likely exit early (Autogirl: trade sale).	Build an investor base whose return expectations fit that exit.	Plan the listing or secondary route; a domestic exchange works for local-asset businesses (MNT-Halan).

Figure 40 Indicative stage guidance across nine dimensions, with the case that evidences each cell. Source: Section 07, Step 3.

SECTION 08

08



Implications for investors

1

Underwrite the capital structure, not only the company.

A strong team with a sound product can still fail if asset-intensive operations are funded with equity or if debt depends on one platform; Sendy and Moove illustrate these risks, alongside other causes. Investors who push portfolio companies to raise larger equity rounds for inventory, fleets or working capital may be adding risk.

2

Diligence the risk transfer in partner models.

An asset-light company is only as asset-light as its contracts: investors should review the insurance, guarantee, escrow and title terms that shift risk to owners, logistics partners and lenders, and test whether they are enforced.

3

Help founders build debt capacity early.

M-KOPA and MNT-Halan could borrow at scale, and years of repayment data that lenders could underwrite appear to be one reason. Investors can help by requiring clean receivables reporting from the first financed asset and introducing lenders and DFIs early, while testing whether the business's cash flows can carry debt.

4

Close the lead-investor gap at pre-seed.

Three of the nine companies reached the market on grants, prizes and small cheques with no clear lead for a priced round. Investors able to lead small priced rounds for companies with proven partner models may gain a sourcing advantage.

5

Align expectations with the exit.

MNT-Halan's listing suggests that a domestic exchange can provide liquidity; Autogirl's trade-sale goal shows that some founders build for moderate outcomes. Funds should back companies whose likely exit fits their return model and leave the rest to investors whose models fit them.

6

Distinguish suitability from availability.

A structure that suits a business in principle, such as local-currency securitisation, may not exist in its market. Investors should establish which lenders, markets and licences are actually accessible before recommending a capital structure.

SECTION 09

09

Conclusion



This capstone asked how a set of African founders have used capital as a strategic tool, and what founders and investors can learn from them. Across nine fintech and logistics companies, the answer is a set of connected principles, not a single rule to raise less or raise later.

1 The first and most important principle is that **capital strategy starts with the asset**. M-KOPA and MNT-Halan fund owned assets with diversified debt and Moniepoint can draw on deposits, each reserving equity mainly for the platform; Autogirl, Feegor and Earthbond leave assets with partners; NALA and LemFi built their core payments businesses on equity and have since added debt-related activity as float and credit needs emerged. The two outcomes at the other end are consistent with this principle but do not prove it: Sendy, which funded asset-intensive lines with equity, closed in 2023, and Moove, whose Nigerian vehicle finance was linked to Uber, left Nigeria in 2026. Execution, unit economics, market conditions and platform concentration also played a part.

2 The second principle is **sequence**. Several founders left risk with partners until they had the data to price it, then brought assets onto their own balance sheets once lenders were available. This is a heuristic that depends on context, not a path every company should follow.

3 The third is **timing**: founders who raised from strength attracted strong investors in difficult markets, although the terms they obtained are rarely public.

4 The fourth is **investor selection**: the founders studied chose, or attracted, investors for specific contributions and changed the composition of their investor base as their capital needs, customer markets and exit plans developed.

The study has limits. It is an exploratory comparison of nine purposively selected cases based on public sources, and it does not establish causality. Case selection favours companies with strong public records, and only one failed company is examined in full. The three early-stage companies do not meet the success test, so their outcomes remain open. Dilution is inferred from capital structure rather than measured, and debt terms are rarely disclosed. Several facts rest on founder statements and press coverage, and some, such as the structure of Autogirl's Prado offer, could not be verified. The East and North Africa set lacks an early-stage case. Future research could use prospectus and secondary-transaction data, such as MNT-Halan's listing documents, to measure dilution directly, and founder interviews to test the reasons behind the decisions described here.

Within those limits, the cases are consistent with the view that capital strategy, not only capital quantum, helps separate founders who build durable businesses from those who build impressive funding announcements. What the cases reasonably establish is that the asset and its risks shaped every company's financing options. What they suggest is that matching the instrument, the owner and the currency to the asset is associated with greater resilience. What remains uncertain is how far these patterns hold beyond fintech and logistics and outside the markets studied. The African ecosystem would benefit from celebrating funding rounds less and examining financing decisions more: why, when, how, from whom and on whose balance sheet.

What the study can and cannot claim

What the cases establish	What they suggest	What remains uncertain
The asset and its risks shaped every company's financing options.	Matching the instrument, the owner and the currency to the asset is associated with greater resilience.	How far these patterns hold beyond fintech and logistics and outside the markets studied.

Figure 41 The conclusion in three panels. Source: Section 09.

> *Capital strategy, not only capital quantum, helps separate founders who build durable businesses from those who build impressive funding announcements.*

Notes on sources

STATUS AT 25 OCTOBER 2026

1. **Sources and dates.** Every case draws on public sources checked up to 25 October 2026. Events from 2026, including MNT-Halan's EGX listing, Moove's exit from Nigeria and NALA's credit facility, rely on press reports close to that date.

2. **Reported, not confirmed.** LemFi's Series B extension of about €30M and M-KOPA's Series F of about $160M had been reported but not announced as closed at that date.

3. **Autogirl's Prado offer.** The offer and the figures attributed to it (520+ vehicles, 20,000+ rentals and ₦2B+ paid to owners) come from company materials and are company-reported. The offer's amount, instrument, title holder and any return guarantee are not public, so the case leaves its classification unresolved.

ABOUT THE CITATIONS

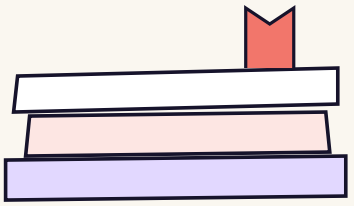
Material claims are cited in the text as (Outlet, Month Year) and listed by case in the references that follow, from page 54.

ILLUSTRATIONS

All illustrations and charts were drawn for this report. No company logos or press photographs are used.

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APPENDIX A

Glossary of terms

The abbreviations and terms below are used throughout this capstone. Currency amounts are in US dollars unless stated otherwise; dollar equivalents of naira, shilling, pound and euro figures are approximate and use the rates given in the cited reports.

3PL	Third-party logistics: an outside provider that handles delivery and fulfilment on a company's behalf
ARR	Annual recurring revenue
Asset capital	Financing for an identifiable asset or receivable (a loan book, devices, payment float, inventory, vehicles or warehouses), as distinct from platform capital
AVCA	Africa Private Capital Association (formerly the African Private Equity and Venture Capital Association)
B / bn	Billion (e.g. $1.5B)
B2B	Business-to-business
BII	British International Investment, the UK's development finance institution (formerly CDC Group)
BMZ	German Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development (Bundesministerium für wirtschaftliche Zusammenarbeit und Entwicklung)
BNPL	Buy-now-pay-later: short-term credit that lets a buyer pay for goods in instalments
CDC	CDC Group, former name of British International Investment (BII)
CEO	Chief executive officer
CIB	Commercial International Bank (Egypt)
COO	Chief operating officer
COVID-19	Coronavirus disease of 2019
Credit facility	A committed borrowing limit from a lender that a company can draw on. A facility is not a loan book, and the amount drawn may be less than the amount available
DFI	Development finance institution: a government-backed lender or investor with a development mandate
DPI	Development Partners International, an Africa-focused private equity firm
EBRD	European Bank for Reconstruction and Development
EGP	Egyptian pound
EGX	Egyptian Exchange, Egypt's stock exchange
EIB	European Investment Bank
EU	European Union
FMO	Dutch Entrepreneurial Development Bank (Nederlandse Financierings-Maatschappij voor Ontwikkelingslanden)
FSD Africa	Financial Sector Deepening Africa
FX	Foreign exchange
GET	Grooming Endowment Trust (GET Accelerated programme)
GIZ	Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit, Germany's development cooperation agency
GMV	Gross merchandise value: the total value of goods sold through a marketplace
HBS	Harvard Business School
IFC	International Finance Corporation, the private-sector arm of the World Bank Group
IPO	Initial public offering
k	Thousand (e.g. $405.1k)
KES	Kenyan shilling
KfW	German state-owned development bank (Kreditanstalt für Wiederaufbau)
KYC	Know your customer: identity and risk checks on customers
Loan book	The portfolio of loans or receivables a company has extended to customers and carries on its own balance sheet
LP	Limited partner: an investor in a venture capital or private equity fund
M	Million (e.g. $55M)
M&A	Mergers and acquisitions
MBA	Master of Business Administration
MUFG	Mitsubishi UFJ Financial Group (MUFG Bank)
MWh	Megawatt-hour
₦	Nigerian naira
PE	Private equity
Platform capital	Financing for technology, people, licences, compliance and market entry, which create no separable asset a lender can underwrite
POS	Point of sale (card and payment terminals)
SAFE	Simple agreement for future equity: a convertible instrument that becomes equity at a later priced round
SaaS	Software as a service
Securitisation	Pooling loans or receivables in a separate vehicle that issues bonds to investors, repaid from the pooled collections
SKU	Stock-keeping unit: a distinct product listed for sale
SME	Small and medium-sized enterprise
SUV	Sport utility vehicle
UAE	United Arab Emirates
UK	United Kingdom
US / USD	United States / United States dollar
VC	Venture capital (or venture capitalist)

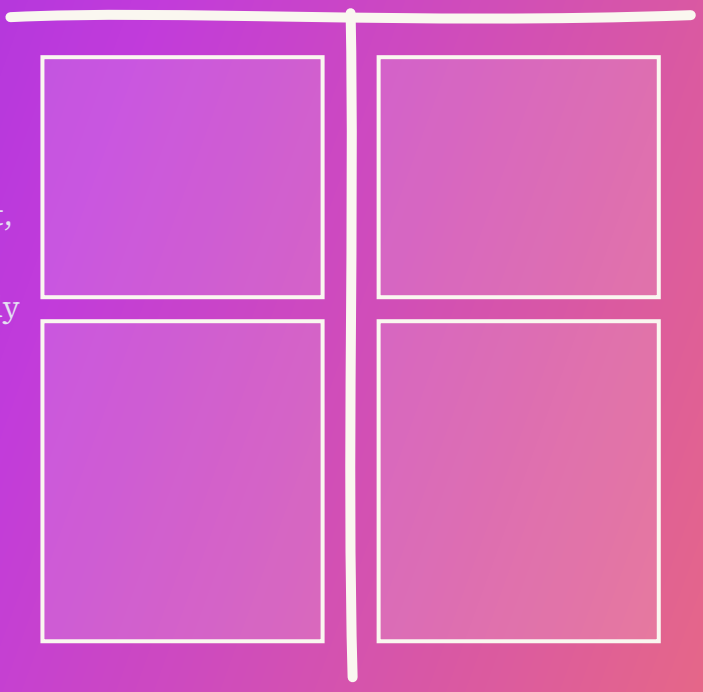
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Who carries the asset?

How African founders use capital as a strategic tool: nine cases, one framework

Princess Oti · Abdullahi Lawal · Nate Cheruiyot

Available capital is not necessarily suitable capital. Asking whose balance sheet should carry each asset, and which instrument fits it, before asking how much can be raised separates the deliberate founders in this study from the reactive ones.



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